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COMMERCE MINISTRY SAYS, 45% EXPORTS REMAIN EXEMPT

'US cuts additional Section 301 tariff on India to 10%'

The Ministry of Commerce and Industry said final measures were announced by Office of USTR on July 23

NEW DELHI: The United States has reduced the additional tariff on Indian imports under its Section 301 forced labour measures to 10 per cent from the 12.5 per cent proposed earlier, with nearly 45 per cent of India's exports to the US remaining outside the scope of the new duty, the Ministry of Commerce & Industry said.

In a statement issued on Saturday, the ministry said the final measures were announced by the Office of the US Trade Representative (USTR) on July 23 following its investigation into the acts, policies and practices of 60 economies, including India, relating to the prohibition of imports produced with forced labour.

The ministry said, "USTR has imposed an additional 10 per cent ad valorem duty on imports from India. This is a reduction from the 12.5 per cent duty initially proposed on 2nd June 2026." According to the ministry, India's continued engagement with the US during the investigation helped secure a lower tariff category compared with many other economies.

"The Government of India remained closely engaged with USTR throughout the investigation through detailed written submissions and in-person consultations, including participation in public hearings. As a result of these sustained efforts, India has been placed in the lower tier of additional tariffs under the final measures, providing a relative advantage to Indian exports in key sectors," the statement said.

The ministry said several major export categories would remain unaffected by the additional tariff.

It noted that generic pharmaceuticals, smartphones and certain other specified products continue to attract no additional duty under the Section 301 action.

Products already covered under Section 232 measures, including steel, aluminium and auto parts, are also excluded from the new 10 per cent duty. ANI

'India's continued engagement with the US helped secure a lower tariff category'

HIGHLIGHTS

- The commerce ministry noted that generic pharmaceuticals, smartphones & certain other specified products continue to attract no additional duty
- Products under Section 232 measures, including aluminium, steel and auto parts, are also excluded from new duty

SAMUDRA MANTHAN MISSION

ONGC starts drilling 1st deepwater exploratory well in Mahanadi basin

Minister of Petroleum and Natural Gas Hardeep Singh Puri virtually spudded ONGC's exploratory well, MN-DW18-1-H-D from New Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corporation on Saturday commenced drilling its first deepwater exploratory well in the Mahanadi offshore basin, marking the start of an ambitious campaign to tap India's deep and ultra-deepwater hydrocarbon resources.

Minister of Petroleum and Natural Gas Hardeep Singh Puri virtually spudded ONGC's exploratory well, MN-DW18-1-H-D, in the Mahanadi Offshore Basin from New Delhi on Saturday, under the government's Samudra Manthan mission.

The well is being drilled around 23 nautical miles from the Konark discovery off the Odisha coast, building on ONGC's recent Utkal and Konark discoveries that have strengthened the hydrocarbon prospectivity of the Mahanadi Offshore Basin.

The drilling campaign forms part of the push to accelerate exploration of India's offshore oil and gas reserves. In his Independence Day address on August 15, 2025, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had called for harnessing the country's untapped offshore hydrocarbon potential.

In line with that vision, the government has opened nearly one million square kilometres of previously restricted offshore areas for exploration, paving the way for fresh acreage to be offered under upcoming rounds of the Open Acreage Licensing Policy (OALP).

India's eastern and western offshore basins, extending to water depths of up to 3,000 metres, are estimated to hold more than 5,600 million metric tonnes of oil equivalent of hydrocarbon resources.

Recent exploration successes in the Cauvery, Mahanadi and Andaman basins have further strengthened the outlook for offshore exploration, according to the statement.

To support the deepwater exploration programme, ONGC in January this year launched its flagship Deepwater Exploration Mission Centre, DeepX, in Mumbai.

The centre integrates the company's geoscientific expertise, advanced interpretation capabilities, specialised training and global collaborations under its "One Company, One Data" philosophy.

The company said the commencement of drilling marks the beginning of one of India's most challenging deepwater exploration campaigns, aimed at boosting domestic oil and gas production, reducing import dependence and strengthening the country's energy security.

AU Small Finance Bank Q1 net profit rises 37% to ₹796 cr

NEW DELHI: AU Small Finance Bank (SFB) on Saturday reported a 37 per cent year-on-year rise in net profit to Rs 796 crore for Q1 FY27, driven by strong growth in net interest income and lower provisions. Net profit stood at Rs 581 crore in Q1 FY26. NII rose 32 per cent YoY to Rs 2,696 crore from Rs 2,045 crore, while operating profit rose 9.4 per cent to Rs 1,435 crore. Asset quality remained largely stable, with gross NPAs inching up to 2.10 per cent from 2.03 per cent in Q4. Net NPAs also rose to 0.76 per cent from 0.74 per cent.

Provisions fell 30 per cent YoY to Rs 371 crore from Rs 533 crore, despite including a one-time provision of Rs 23 crore to strengthen provisioning for microfinance, personal and business loans, two-wheelers and EEFI businesses. However, provisions were higher than Rs 269 crore in the preceding quarter. Total deposits grew 24 per cent YoY to Rs 1.58 lakh crore, while CASA deposits rose 22 per cent, with the CASA ratio at 29 per cent. The gross loan portfolio expanded 23 per cent YoY to Rs 1.44 lakh crore, supported by a 42 per cent increase in loan disbursements. Annualised credit cost improved to 0.8 per cent from 1.4 per cent a year earlier. AGENCIES

IDFC First Bank posts Q1 profit of ₹1,075 cr

NEW DELHI: IDFC First Bank on Saturday reported its highest-ever quarterly PAT of Rs 1,075 crore in April-June period of the current fiscal year, up 132.4 per cent from Rs 463 crore in the year-ago period.

Total customer business increased to Rs 6,04,776 crore as of June 30, 2026 from Rs 5,10,031 crore as of June 30, 2025, a growth of 18.6 per cent, the bank said in a stock exchange filing.

The bank further said its loans and advances rose to Rs 3,05,370 crore as of June 30, 2026 from Rs 2,53,233 crore as of June 30, 2025, a growth of 20.6 per cent.

Gross NPA of the bank improved to 1.51 per cent as of June 30, 2026 from 1.97 per cent as of June 30, 2025. Net NPA, too, improved to 0.44 per cent from 0.55 per cent as of June 30, 2025. PTI

IMPORTANT NOTICE

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENTS FOR
KANWAR MELA-2026

For the convenience of Kanwariyas during Kanwar Mela-2026, Northern Railway has decided to run Kanwar Special Trains, extend the nominated train services upto Haridwar and to provide temporary stoppages to some of existing services, The details are as under:-

Extension of Train No. 74023/74022 Delhi Jn.-Shamli-Delhi Jn. DEMU upto Haridwar (Daily)

Train No. 74023 ARR.	Train No. 74023 DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 74022 ARR.	Train No. 74022 DEP.
---	20:00	Delhi Jn.	09:25	---
No Change between Delhi-Shamli				
22:50	22:55	Shamli	06:25	06:30
23:20	23:22	Thana Bhawan	05:11	05:12
23:44	23:45	Rampur Maniharan	04:47	04:48
00:15	00:17	Tapri	04:32	04:33
00:56	00:58	Roorkee	04:03	04:05
01:38	01:40	Jwalapur	03:15	03:17
01:55	---	**Haridwar**	---	**03:05**

Days of run : 74023 Ex. Delhi Jn. from 30.07.2026 to 13.08.2026 (Daily) and **74022 Ex. Haridwar** from 31.07.2026 to 14.08.2026 (Daily).
Composition: General

Extension of Train No. 64557/64558 Delhi Jn.-Saharanpur-Delhi MEMU Jn. upto Haridwar (Daily)

Train No. 64557 ARR.	Train No. 64557 DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 64558 ARR.	Train No. 64558 DEP.
---	16:15	Delhi Jn.	08:45	---
No Change between Delhi-Saharanpur				
20:50	21:10	Saharanpur	03:40	04:20
21:48	21:50	Roorkee	02:53	02:55
22:25	22:27	Jwalapur	02:10	02:12
22:50	---	**Haridwar**	---	**02:00**

Days of run : 64557 Ex. Delhi Jn. from 30.07.2026 to 13.08.2026 (Daily) and **64558 Ex. Haridwar** from 31.07.2026 to 14.08.2026 (Daily).
Composition: General

RUN OF MELA SPECIAL TRAINS
AS PER TIME-TABLE GIVEN BELOW

04314/04313 Haridwar-Delhi Shahdara-Haridwar Unreserved Mela Special (Daily)

Train No. 04314 ARR.	Train No. 04314 DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04313 ARR.	Train No. 04313 DEP.
---	15:30	Haridwar	04:25	---
20:40	---	Delhi Shahdara	---	22:25

Days of run : 04314 Ex. Haridwar and **04313 Ex. Delhi Shahdara** from 30.07.2026 to 13.08.2026 (Daily)
Composition: Sleeper/General
Stoppages: Jwalapur, Roorkee, Tapri Jn., Muzaffarnagar, Meerut City & Ghaziabad Stations.

04316/04315 Yog Nagari Rishikesh-Delhi Shahdara-Yog Nagari Rishikesh Unreserved Mela Special (Daily)

Train No. 04316 ARR.	Train No. 04316 DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04315 ARR.	Train No. 04315 DEP.
---	20:35	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	11:00	---
03:50	---	Delhi Shahdara	---	04:20

Days of run : 04316 Ex. Yog Nagari Rishikesh from 30.07.2026 to 13.08.2026 (Daily) and **04315 Ex. Delhi Shahdara** from 31.07.2026 to 14.08.2026 (Daily).
Composition: Sleeper/General
Stoppages: Raiwala Jn., Motichur, Haridwar, Jwalapur, Roorkee, Tapri Jn., & Shamli Stations.

For detailed information, please call RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit enquiry website: www.enquiry.indianrail.gov.in

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04318/04317 Yog Nagari Rishikesh-Alamnagar-Yog Nagari Rishikesh Unreserved Mela Special (Daily)

Train No. 04318 ARR.	Train No. 04318 DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04317 ARR.	Train No. 04317 DEP.
---	19:00	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	23:00	---
10:45	---	Alamnagar	---	12:05

Days of run : 04318 Ex. Yog Nagari Rishikesh from 30.07.2026 to 28.08.2026 (Daily) and **04317 Ex. Alamnagar** from 31.07.2026 to 29.08.2026 (Daily).
Composition: Sleeper/General
Stoppages: Raiwala Jn., Motichur, Haridwar, Jwalapur, Laksar Jn., Balawali, Muazzampur Narayan Jn., Najibabad Jn., Moradabad, Rampur Jn., Bareilly & Shahjahanpur Jn. Stations.

TEMPORARY STOPPAGES OF TRAINS FROM 30.07.2026 TO 13.08.2026

Train No. & Name	Frequency	Temporary Stoppages	Timings ARR.	Timings DEP.
14113 Subedarganj-Dehradun Express	Daily	Raiwala Jn.	11:14	11:16
		Motichur	11:04	11:06
		Jwalapur	10:43	10:45
14114 Dehradun-Subedarganj Express	Daily	Raiwala Jn.	14:10	14:12
		Motichur	14:34	14:36
		Jwalapur	15:15	15:17
14309 Lakshmibai Nagar-Yog Nagari Rishikesh Express	Bi-Weekly	Raiwala Jn.	17:35	17:37
		Motichur	17:00	17:02
		Jwalapur	15:53	15:55
14310 Yog Nagari Rishikesh-Lakshmibai Nagar Express	Bi-Weekly	Raiwala Jn.	07:08	07:10
		Motichur	07:24	07:26
		Jwalapur	07:52	07:54
14317 Lakshmibai Nagar-Yog Nagari Rishikesh Express	Bi-Weekly	Raiwala Jn.	17:35	17:37
		Motichur	17:00	17:02
		Jwalapur	15:53	15:55
14318 Yog Nagari Rishikesh-Lakshmibai Nagar Express	Bi-Weekly	Raiwala Jn.	07:08	07:10
		Motichur	07:24	07:26
		Jwalapur	07:52	07:54
19565 Okha-Dehradun Express	Weekly	Raiwala Jn.	17:35	17:37
		Motichur	17:00	17:02
		Jwalapur	15:53	15:55
19566 Dehradun-Okha Express	Weekly	Raiwala Jn.	07:08	07:10
		Motichur	07:24	07:26
		Jwalapur	07:52	07:54
22659 Thiruvananthapuram-Yog Nagari Rishikesh Superfast Express	Weekly	Raiwala Jn.	13:04	13:06
		Motichur	12:52	12:54
		Jwalapur	12:08	12:10
22660 Yog Nagari Rishikesh-Thiruvananthapuram Superfast Express	Weekly	Raiwala Jn.	07:08	07:10
		Motichur	07:24	07:26
		Jwalapur	07:52	07:54
14610 Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra-Yog Nagari Rishikesh Hemkund Express	Daily	Motichur	07:20	07:22
		Jwalapur	06:48	06:50
14609 Yog Nagari Rishikesh- Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra Hemkund Express	Daily	Jwalapur	18:31	18:33
54075 Bareilly-Delhi Jn. Passenger	Daily	Kankather	23:36	23:38
54076 Delhi Jn.-Bareilly Passenger	Daily	Kankather	02:40	02:42
14815 Shri Ganganagar-Rishikesh Express	Daily	Raiwala Jn.	14:16	14:18
		Motichur	13:54	13:56
		Jwalapur	13:24	13:26
14816 Rishikesh-Shri Ganganagar Express	Daily	Raiwala Jn.	13:35	13:37
		Motichur	14:02	14:04
		Jwalapur	14:28	14:30

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DRI seizes 27 kg smuggled gold, arrests 12 in nationwide crackdown

NEW DELHI: The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has seized over 27 kg of foreign-origin smuggled gold and arrested 12 people in intelligence-led operations across the country, exposing organised smuggling networks using aircraft lavatories, modified vehicles, utensils and body concealment.

According to a Finance Ministry statement issued on Saturday, the operations revealed "sophisticated concealment methods," reflecting the evolving tactics of organised smuggling syndicates.

The largest seizure was made in Mumbai on July 23-24, when DRI officers intercepted three passengers arriving from Addis Ababa.

After searching the aircraft, officials recovered six foreign-origin gold bars weighing about 12 kg hidden inside the ceiling panels of the rear lavatory.

Investigators said the passengers had concealed the gold for retrieval by airport staff. All three were arrested.

In Uttar Pradesh, DRI officers intercepted a woman travelling on the Brahmaputra Mail on July 23 and recovered about 5 kg of smuggled gold concealed in a waist belt and handbag.

She allegedly admitted the gold had been smuggled into India through Bangladesh.

Another operation at Mumbai Airport uncovered a syndicate using aircraft lavatories to hide 3.7 kg of gold dust in wax form for retrieval by cleaning staff.

Five people, including the carrier, handler, recipient and airport cleaners, were arrested.

Separately, DRI seized 4.6 kg of gold hidden inside specially fabricated utensils from a passenger at Kolkata Railway Station, with investigations pointing to Myanmar as the source.

In separate operations at Cochin and Guwahati, officers recovered about 2 kg of smuggled gold concealed inside a passenger's body and a modified car, arresting two more people. AGENCIES

NTPC board approves raising up to ₹12K crore via NCDs

NEW DELHI: State-run power giant NTPC's board has approved a plan to raise up to Rs 12,000 crore via issuance of non-convertible debentures (NCDs).

The Board of Directors of the company, at its meeting held on Friday, July 24, 2026, approved the issue of non-convertible debentures up to Rs 12,000 crore, in one or more tranches through private placement in the domestic market, the company said in a regulatory filing on Friday evening.

The company said the issuance period will commence from the date of passing of the special resolution until completion of one year thereof or the date of the next Annual General Meeting in the financial year 2027-28, whichever is earlier.

The size, tenor, listing details (BSE and/or NSE), coupon/interest rate, security, if applicable, and other applicable details will be decided at the time of issue of each tranche/series, the filing said.

In another filing, giving operational and financial highlights in the April-June quarter this year, the company said its group installed capacity has increased to 90,904 MW as on June 30, 2026, from 82,646 MW as on June 30, 2025. PTI

PhonePe's consolidated revenue grows to ₹7,920 crore in FY26

NEW DELHI: Demonstrating strong top-line momentum, PhonePe's consolidated revenue from operations rose to Rs 7,920 crore in FY26, according to regulatory filings with the Registrar of Companies (RoC).

This represents a top-line expansion of Rs 815 crore, marking an 11.47 per cent increase compared to the previous fiscal year.

As the government is yet to release the UPI Digital Incentive (DI) funds for FY2025-26 to the industry, the revenue associated with DI has not been recognized in FY26.

This portion of the FY26-related DI revenue is expected to accrue in PhonePe's FY2026-27 financials.

On a normalized operational basis, PhonePe's net loss for FY26 stood at Rs 1,377 crore while the total consolidated net loss was reported at Rs 2,792 crore (vs. Rs 1,727 crore in FY2024-25). Notably, the FY26 net loss included several one-time items: a one-time ESOP acceleration charge, a non-cash goodwill impairment, a gain on the sale of a partial stake in an associate, and losses from discontinued operations.

Beyond core payments, PhonePe continues to deepen its presence as a multi-sector fintech ecosystem.

The company has successfully secured regulatory licenses to operate across a wide spectrum of financial services, including payment aggregation, insurance broking, wealth management, and lending.

PhonePe also continues to receive strong corporate backing from major global institutional investors, with Walmart (via WM Digital Commerce Holdings Pte Ltd) retaining a dominant 73.33 per cent stake. PTI

Birla Corp posts Q1 net profit of ₹115.73 cr

Birla Corporation had posted a net profit of Rs 119.57 crore for Q1 FY26

NEW DELHI: M P Birla Group firm Birla C orporation on Saturday reported an on-year decline of 3.2 per cent in consolidated net profit to Rs 115.73 crore in the June quarter of this fiscal year, due to subdued realisation from cement sales and escalation in power and fuel costs.

Birla Corporation had posted a net profit of Rs 119.57 crore for the April-June period a year ago, the company said in a regulatory filing. However, Birla Corporation's revenue from operations was up 7.8 per cent to Rs 2,646.45 crore in the June quarter of FY27. It was at Rs 2,454.22 crore in the corresponding period a year ago.

During the quarter, cement prices remained under pressure: price hikes introduced in April-May had to be rolled back in June amid intense competition for market share, Birla Corporation said an earnings statement.

Total expenses of Birla Corporation were at Rs 2,513.71 crore, up 8.87 per cent in the June quarter.

Birla Corporation's revenue from the Cement business was up 7.4 per cent to Rs 2,515.17 crore in the first quarter of FY27. It was at Rs 2,341.86 crore in the corresponding quarter.

The company's cement sales by volume grew by 5 per cent to 5.05 Metric Tonnes, helped by "sustained gains in the trade segment in states such as Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan."

However, "realisation from cement sales for the quarter was at Rs 4,947 per ton, up almost 2 per cent yoy, but EBITDA per ton was 6 per cent lower at Rs 675. This was largely on account of a 5 per cent increase in power and fuel cost. The Cement Division's EBITDA margin for the quarter was at 13.6 per cent, down 110 basis points from the same period last year," it said.

Birla Corporation's revenue from the Jute division was down 16.7 per cent to Rs 131.25 crore. Jute Mills faced another challenging quarter with raw jute prices shooting to a record high. PTI

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CITY: PG 5
CM Gupta salutes Pradhan's edu legacy

NATION: PG 8
Students' agitation warning to BJP-RSS: Rahul Gandhi

FILM: PG 14
Was spoilt for choice when it came to lessons: Tom Holland

FROM 'COCKROACHES' TO CONQUERORS: CJP CALLS OFF AGITATION AFTER GOVT ACCEPTS ALL DEMANDS

Students pass, Minister resigns

Don't want anti-national elements to take advantage, says Pradhan

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: What began as a small gathering of students determined to seek accountability over the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak ended on Saturday as one of the most significant youth-led protest movements in recent Indian history.

After 36 days of continuous demonstrations at Delhi's Jantar Mantar and protests that spread across the country, Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned, becoming the first Union minister to step down following sustained public protests. Within hours, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) announced the withdrawal of its nationwide agitation after the Centre accepted all its principal demands, bringing to a close a movement that had transformed from a student sit-in into a nationwide campaign for accountability and examination reforms.

Soon after Pradhan's resignation, Pralhad Joshi was given additional charge of the Ministry of Education while continuing to hold the portfolios of New and Renewable Energy and Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution. Pradhan's resignation was accepted by President Droupadi Murmu with immediate effect, under clause (2) of Article 75 of the Constitution of India.

Continued on P6

Union Minister JP Nadda with MoS Jitendra Singh and CJP Spokespersons Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, during a joint press conference after Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned from the Union Cabinet, at the Constitution Club of India, in New Delhi, on Saturday PTI

AFTER 36 DAYS

- After 36 days of continuous demonstrations at Delhi's Jantar Mantar and protests that spread across the country, Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned, becoming the first Union minister to step down following sustained public protests
- Within hours, the CJP announced the withdrawal of its nationwide agitation after the Centre accepted all its principal demands
- Pradhan's resignation was accepted by President Droupadi Murmu with immediate effect, under clause (2) of Article 75 of the Constitution of India

» PRADHAN'S RESIGNATION victory of democracy, time for reforms now: Wangchuk

RISE & FALL: NEP face to resignation

NEW DELHI: From becoming BJP's go-to election manager for difficult states and handling key ministries in three tenures of the Modi government to resigning as Education Minister, Dharmendra Pradhan's political career faced an unexpected jolt after flaring nationwide protests over the NEET paper leak.

As Education Minister, Pradhan became the public face of the implementation of the ambitious National Education Policy (NEP). However, his final years in office were overshadowed by repeated controversies surrounding competitive examinations and allegations of saffronisation of school textbooks.

The resignation marked a significant departure from the government's initial dismissive response to the agitation. Pradhan himself had escalated the confrontation in June by describing Continued on P6

Better late than never: MM Joshi

NEW DELHI: After Dharmendra Pradhan stepped down as Union education minister, veteran BJP leader Murli Manohar Joshi on Saturday congratulated students for the "peaceful conclusion" of their agitation.

Commenting on the development, Joshi said in a post on X, "Better late than never. Shri Dharmendra Pradhan has submitted his resignation."

"I appreciate and congratulate all the students for their peaceful conclusion to the movement. I hope that now, peace will soon be established in the world of Indian education and that the young people will have ample opportunities for their bright future and progress," the BJP veteran added. Continued on P6

> Time has come to remove this govt, 'daro mat'
> **Rahul Gandhi**

In today's paper ...

BUSINESS
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INTERNATIONAL
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SPORT
INDIA SEAL SERIES 9

FOLLOWING PRADHAN'S EXIT

Pralhad Joshi takes education helm

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Union Minister Pralhad Joshi has been appointed as Education Minister following Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation from the post on Saturday.

Joshi has been given additional charge of the Education Ministry besides his role as Consumer Affairs Minister.

A Rashtrapati Bhavan communique said the President, as advised by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has accepted the resignation of Pradhan with immediate effect.

It said that on the advice of the Prime Minister, the President has directed that Joshi, Cabinet Minister, be assigned the charge of the Ministry of Education, in addition to his own duties.

Meanwhile, BJP leaders acknowledged Dharmedra Pradhan's contributions after he resigned as Union education minister on Saturday, with Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju describing his journey as a "testament" to lifelong engagement with public life and student welfare.

Several other Union ministers, including Jitendra Singh, Piyush Goyal, Virendra Kumar, Giriraj Singh and G Kishan Reddy, also lauded Pradhan's contributions, saying his tenure reflected a strong commitment to strengthening the education ecosystem.

BJP president Nitin Nabin said that Pradhan, as a Union education minister, played a "pivotal role" in reforming India's education landscape and successfully implementing the "landmark" National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, among other initiatives.

"Prioritising larger interests, his decision to step down reflects the highest standards of integrity and selfless service in public life. The party stands firmly with Shri Dharmendra Pradhan Ji in this decision," Nabin said in a post on X.

Union Minister Jitendra Singh said Pradhan's tenure as the education minister reflected a strong commitment to strengthening the education ecosystem, guided by "conviction, energy and a clear sense of purpose".

He said Pradhan navigated the complexities of educational leadership while keeping students at the centre.

EDUCATION RESET

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- A Rashtrapati Bhavan communique said the President, as advised by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has accepted the resignation of Pradhan with immediate effect

Maha TET leak kingpin nabbed

Held in Bihar with another accused

MPOST BUREAU

THANE: The alleged mastermind of Maharashtra Teacher Eligibility Test (TET) 2026 paper leak case was arrested from Bihar along with one more person, a senior Thane police official said on Saturday.

Alleged kingpin Vijayendrakumar Gupta alias Bijendra Kumar Gupta and his associate Indrajit Singh were nabbed from the eastern state on Friday by the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the case, Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP), Bhiwandi Zone-II, Pawan Bansode said.

It takes the total number of arrests in the case to 14, Bansode said.

Gupta and Singh were brought to Pune on Saturday and then to Bhiwandi, where they will be produced in court for police remand to carry out custodial interrogation, the DCP informed.

The SIT had been tracking Gupta for several weeks after his name surfaced as the chief coordinator of the inter-state paper leak network, Bansode said.

Apart from Gupta and Singh, the others arrested in the case so far include Rajiv Shaw, Akash Kumar, Dheeraj Singh, Sonu Singh, Mithun Singh, Kapil Dahiya, Gupta's wife Suman Kumari Gupta, and Agra-based private printing press employees Nareshkumar Mahore, Sanjaykumar Sharma, Continued on P6

BIG CATCH

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Min Pradhan's exit joins short list of Modi govt's cilmbdowns since 2014

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation on Saturday over the NEET paper leak controversy was not the sole instance when the Narendra Modi government yielded to sustained public or political pressure since coming to power in 2014.

The first major retreat came in 2015 when the government sought to amend the land acquisition law to make it easier to acquire land for infrastructure and industrial projects.

The move triggered widespread opposition from farmer organisations, opposition parties and several NDA allies, who argued that the changes diluted existing safeguards and were anti-people. The government eventually allowed the proposal to lapse. Modi announced that the existing law would remain unchanged.

Three years later came the first ministerial resignation under public pressure.

In October 2018, then minister of state for external affairs M J Akbar resigned during the Me Too movement after several women accused him of sexual harassment during his days as an editor. Akbar denied the allegations but stepped down. Continued on P6

TAKEAWAYS

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- The move triggered widespread opposition from farmer organisations, opposition parties and several NDA allies, who argued that the changes diluted existing safeguards and were anti-people
- In October 2018, then minister of state for external affairs M J Akbar resigned during the Me Too movement

KARGIL VIJAY DIWAS

Army personnel light candles during Vijay Diwas celebrations at the Kargil War Memorial, in Drass, Kargil district PTI

France & Spain battle wildfires

LEGE-CAP FERRET (FRANCE): France cut the length of the Tour de France's final stage on Saturday to redeploy officers to battle raging wildfires that forced the evacuation of tens of thousands of people, including from some of the suburbs of the wine region city of Bordeaux.

A specially adapted cargo aircraft was deployed to dump flame retardants on a huge blaze raging in the Gironde region of southwestern France. The Tour de France's last stage on Sunday will be reduced in length by a third, the Paris police department said. See P4

WATERS BEGIN TO RECEDE IN SOME PARTS

Assam floods: 61 dead, 7 lakh affected; PM dials CM

MPOST BUREAU

GUWAHATI: The flood situation in Assam remained grim on Saturday even as the water level has started to recede in some parts, while 61 people have died of the deluge and over 7.05 lakh people are affected in nine districts, officials said.

According to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) bulletin on Friday late night, 14 more people lost their lives in the deluge during the last 24 hours, taking the toll to 61 this year.

Charaideo district witnessed seven people, including two women, drowning in flood waters; followed by six, including one woman, in Sivasagar; and one each in Jorhat, it added.

According to the authority's daily flood report, more than 7,05,100 people have been affected in Charaideo, Dhemaji, Dibrugarh, Golaghat, Hojai, Jorhat, Karbi Anglong, Nagaon and Sivasagar districts.

Sivasagar is the worst-hit district with nearly 3.5 lakh people affected, followed by Charaideo with almost 1.9 lakh people and Jorhat with more than 1.3 lakh people reeling under floodwaters.

The flood situation has improved marginally since Thursday, when over 7.21 lakh people were affected across 11 districts.

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said his government is yet to deliver relief materials to at least 80,000 flood-affected people even as the situation remained critical with many rivers continuing to rise following incessant rains.

"We are trying very hard to reach all the people with relief items, but still many are left out. In Nazira assembly constituency, 30 per cent area or around 50,000 people are not reachable. In Sivasagar, 20 per cent of the area or 30,000 people are inaccessible. The count may be 10,000 more or less (from the 80,000 affected yet to be reached)," he said.

BJP MLA Mayur Borgohain painted a grim and helpless picture of the administration's flood relief efforts in Sivasagar district's Nazira subdivision during a review meeting. Continued on P6

A view of a damaged car, which swept away in a flash flood of the Dikhow River at Bihubar, in Sivasagar on Saturday ANI

CLOSER LOOK

- According to the ASDMA bulletin on Friday late night, 14 more people lost their lives in the deluge during the last 24 hours, taking the toll to 61 this year
- Sivasagar is the worst-hit district with nearly 3.5 lakh people affected, followed by Charaideo with almost 1.9 lakh people and Jorhat with more than 1.3 lakh people reeling under floodwaters
- Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday assured full support to the Assam government in dealing with the flood situation in the state

Russian & Ukrainian officials report 15 dead in latest attacks

The strikes followed a major Russian attack on Friday near Kyiv that killed at least 10 people and wounded around 100 others

MOSCOW: Ukrainian attacks on holiday camps on Saturday in the partly Russian-occupied Zaporizhzhia region have killed 12 people, Moscow-installed officials said, while authorities in Ukraine's northeastern Sumy region said a Russian drone strike killed three people there.

The strikes followed a major Russian attack on Friday near Kyiv that killed at least 10 people and wounded around 100 others, part of a relentless cycle of tit-for-tat attacks that dims the potential of reaching a diplomatic end to Russia's more than 4-year-old invasion of its neighbour.

The exchange comes as Ukraine's successful drone attacks have stalled the Russian army's advances in an expanded campaign by Kyiv inside Russia that has been hitting high-profile targets, causing fuel shortages and piling pressure on Russian leader Vladimir Putin.

Four children were among 12 people killed in the attack on the resorts in Zaporizhzhia, Yevgeny Balitsky, the Kremlin-installed regional head, said, adding that 19 others were wounded.

Sumy regional head Oleh Hryhorov said on Saturday three people were killed when a large fire broke out after a Russian drone struck a "civilian facility," adding that the victims were drivers for private Ukrainian postal and courier service Nova Poshta.

This photo provided by the Ukrainian Emergency Service, shows the site of Russian missile strikes in Kyiv region, Ukraine on Friday AP

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Russia's defence ministry said it attacked a "storage and launch site" for Ukrainian drones in the Sumy region.

In Zaporizhzhia, in southeastern Ukraine, a Russian drone attack late Friday hit a shopping centre, causing a fire that spread over a 500-square-meter area and injuring several people, regional head Ivan Fedorov said.

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy warned in his evening address on Friday that intelligence assessments indicated that Russia was preparing missiles for a large attack, saying there were indications that this could happen in the next 48 hours.

HIGHLIGHTS

- Sumy regional head Oleh Hryhorov said on Saturday three people were killed when a large fire broke out after a Russian drone struck a 'civilian facility'
- Russia's defence ministry said it attacked a 'storage & launch site' for Ukrainian drones in the Sumy region
- In Zaporizhzhia, a Russian drone attack late Friday hit a shopping centre, causing a fire spreading over a 500-square-metre area

Ukraine keeps targeting oil facilities

A Ukrainian drone attack caused a fire in the grounds of the Tyumen Oil Refinery, in western Siberia, Tyumen regional Gov. Aleksandr Moor said on Saturday.

Writing on X Saturday, Zelenskyy confirmed the hit on the Tyumen plant, along with a logistics facility in Yekaterinburg and a fuel and lubricants warehouse in Rostov-on-Don.

Ukraine's long-range drone technology has evolved during the war, posing a problem for Russia, whose huge land mass is hard to protect fully.

Kyiv's forces have targeted Russian oil facilities, causing fuel shortages and embarrassing President Vladimir Putin.

Zelenskyy to meet Trump in Washington

US President Donald Trump and Zelenskyy plan to meet on Tuesday in Washington, a White House official said on Saturday, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss Trump's schedule before it is announced.

Romania shoots down a second drone in 2 days

Romania's defence ministry said on Saturday its forces had "safely shot down" a drone that breached its airspace in an "unpopulated area" near the Ukrainian border. The drone was "shot down by a Romanian pilot from an F-16 aircraft," President Nicu Or Dan said in a post on Facebook.

Saturday's interception came after a drone was shot down around Padina, northeast of the Romanian capital, Bucharest, on Friday. AGENCIES

IN RESPONSE TO STRIKES ON YEMENI CITY

Yemen's Iran-backed Houthis fire missiles, drones at Saudi Arabia

CAIRO: Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels said Saturday that they fired missiles and drones at Saudi Arabia in response to Saudi airstrikes on the strategic Red Sea city of Hodeida, in another escalation over vital shipping routes in the Middle East, while the US & Iran vie for control of the Strait of Hormuz.

Brig. Gen. Yahya Saree, the Houthis' military spokesman, said in a prerecorded statement that the attack targeted facilities in the Red Sea cities of Yanbu and Jizan that belong to Aramco, the world's largest oil company.

Saudi Arabia's civil defence said alerts sounded multiple times early Saturday in both cities, but the Kingdom hasn't commented further. There were no reported strikes overnight in Iran, in an apparent break from nearly two weeks of consecutive nights of US attacks, though tension remains high following a recent escalation between the two countries over the Strait of Hormuz.

Red Sea escalation further threatens global shipping

The rising tension in the Red Sea threatens to further choke global shipping because the rebels have said they would close the Bab el-Mandeb Strait to Saudi-linked shipping.

That strait, at the southern tip of the Arabian Peninsula, is a vital shipping chokepoint, connecting the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden. Around 12 per cent of the world's trade, including a quarter of its container traffic, passes through the narrows.

> 'The attack targeted facilities in the Red Sea cities of Yanbu and Jizan that belong to Aramco, the world's largest oil company'

The Houthis targeted two Saudi oil tankers in the Red Sea this week. In response, Saudi Arabia struck the Yemeni port city of Hodeida, the Saudi-led coalition in Yemen said early Saturday. The strikes late Friday hit the city's port and the state-run telecommunications corporation, injuring two people, said Anees al-Asbahi, a spokesman for the Houthi-run health ministry.

The Saudi-led coalition fighting in Yemen said it didn't hit the port but struck "legitimate military targets" in Hodeida province, which "were linked to threats to commercial vessels in the Red Sea."

Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, called for "diplomacy and dialogue" to solve the Yemen conflict without "military confrontations" in an interview published Saturday in the state-run Iran newspaper.

No new strikes overnight in Iran, but tension remains high

"Iran had a peaceful night," Hossein Kermanpour, a spokesperson for Iran's Health Ministry, posted Saturday on X.

US Central Command didn't immediately respond to a request for comment. However, unlike the previous 13 nights, it didn't announce new strikes.

After the US and Israel attacked Iran in late February, a tenuous ceasefire that halted major operations for several weeks has seemed to unravel this month. The US accused Iran of striking three ships in the Strait of Hormuz and responded by striking dozens of targets in Iran, which retaliated by firing at US-allied Gulf Arab states.

The Strait of Hormuz has been at the centre of the conflict. The US military on Friday fired on a merchant vessel in the Gulf of Oman that was trying to breach its renewed blockade of Iran's ports, while Iran targeted US-allied countries in the region.

US embassies alerted American nationals in the Middle East on Friday that options to leave could become more limited, as Iran's Revolutionary Guard advised residents of neighbouring countries to stay away from bases with US troops.

The war has killed more than 3,400 people in Iran, according to the Iranian Health Ministry. Eighteen US service members, 24 civilians in Israel, and smaller numbers of civilians have been reported dead in countries across the region.

In Lebanon, over 4,000 people have been killed, as well as 38 Israeli troops, after the Hezbollah militants fired at Israel in support of the Iran. AGENCIES

France, Spain battle wildfires as 250,000 displaced

LEGE-CAP FERRET: France cut the length of the Tour de France's final stage on Saturday to redeploy officers to battle raging wildfires that forced the evacuation of tens of thousands of people, including from some of the suburbs of the wine region city of Bordeaux.

A specially adapted cargo aircraft was deployed to dump flame retardants on a huge blaze raging in the Gironde region of southwestern France.

The Tour de France's last stage on Sunday will be reduced in length by a third, the Paris police department said, an extraordinary measure that underscored the gravity of the fires in southwest France.

The riders will race Sunday inside Paris, rather than starting from Thoiry, west of the capital, on a circuit of 89 kilometres (55 miles), down from the 133-kilometre (82.5-mile) route that had been planned. Part of the race's security detail will instead be used "to reinforce the response efforts in the areas affected by the wildfires," the Paris police department said.

Including some 70,000 people evacuated in central Spain, wildfires in southern Europe this week have displaced more than 250,000 people.

French Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said a hulking A400M military transport aircraft will join 18 other water- and retardant-dropping planes and helicopters waging an expected "long and very difficult" battle against the blaze in the Gironde.

With winds expected to shift in a west-to-east direction on Saturday afternoon, potentially driving the fire closer to Bordeaux, fire crews and authorities were digging trenches, using retardants and taking other steps to block it, Nunez said.

He said the fire was about 30 kilometres (20 miles) west of the city and had lost some of its intensity overnight.

The government mobilised soldiers to join the battle and was rushing in 1.5 million face masks to protect against choking smoke.

Authorities ordered people between the fire and Bordeaux to evacuate, including from parts of the city's western suburbs and other towns and villages.

Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu described the fires as unprecedented and said the Gironde blaze became so strong on Friday that it had begun generating its own winds.

"Our priority is clear: protecting human lives," he posted on X, adding that evacuation orders "must be respected without delay."

He said firefighting teams were being reinforced Saturday with the addition of hundreds of soldiers and that breathing masks to filter out smoke particles were being rushed to the Gironde region for those exposed to the clouds of potentially noxious fumes. AGENCIES

More health workers strike as Ebola cases in Congo near 3K, including over 1,300 deaths

BUNIA (Congo): Health workers at an Ebola treatment centre in eastern Congo went on strike Saturday over payment issues, disrupting care for patients in the epicenter of the country's rapidly growing outbreak.

The number of confirmed cases of Ebola in Congo has reached 2,973, including 1,309 deaths, according to government data released Friday in what authorities say is the fastest-growing outbreak on record.

Activities at the Elikya Ebola Treatment Center in Bunia, Ituri province, were largely paralysed after doctors, nurses and security staff stopped work.

About a hundred health workers protested outside the treatment centre on Saturday. They said the unpaid bonuses were undermining morale and disrupting patient care, and called on Congolese authorities to settle the arrears so they could resume their work.

In a statement issued Friday, staff said they had unanimously voted to strike from Saturday until "concrete solutions" were found to resolve "two months of unpaid performance bonuses".

Health workers disinfect a coffin of an Ebola victim at Ebola Treatment Center at Bunia General Hospital in Ituri, Congo AP

Last week, health workers at Bunia General Hospital, the region's largest medical centre, went on strike over unpaid salaries.

Some had told The Associated Press they have not received any payment since they started work at the onset of the outbreak.

The World Health Organisation says more than 100 healthcare workers have been infected since the beginning of the outbreak.

The Central African nation has been battling the Ebola outbreak caused by the rare Bundibugyo virus since May 15. A total of 766 patients remain in isolation or in hospitals, while 540 have recovered so far, according to data from Congo's Ministry of Health.

The eastern province of Ituri accounts for nearly 90% of confirmed cases.

The outbreak continues to spread faster than health officials can track despite an expanding response.

A key challenge is that health authorities have yet to identify the outbreak's patient zero, while displacement from armed conflict and mining-related movements have made it difficult to trace thousands who have come in contact with infected individuals.

The response is being hampered by a funding gap, attacks on health centres, an ongoing conflict in eastern Congo and mistrust among local communities.

Response efforts have also been challenged by the lack of approved vaccines or treatments for the Bundibugyo virus, unlike the more common Zaire virus for which there is a vaccine and which was responsible for most of Congo's past 16 outbreaks of the disease.

Enrollment in a highly anticipated study of two possible Ebola treatments recently started in Ituri. AGENCIES

Israel detains over 70 after deadly West Bank violence

NABLUS: Israel's military said it detained over 70 suspects across the occupied West Bank overnight on Saturday, a day after troops deployed across the territory following violence that left two Israeli soldiers and four Palestinian villagers dead.

Soldiers remained in the village of Tell in the northern West Bank, where Friday's clashes were centred. Palestinians described searches that included raids of a hospital in the city of Nablus, one of the territory's most violent areas.

"More than 50 armed soldiers and officers stormed the hospital, terrifying the patients," Ghassan Barkat, director of Nablus Speciality Hospital, told journalists. He said soldiers on Friday detained, bound and insulted both staff and patients, raided all departments of the hospital and arrested a seriously injured man, Ali Hussein Ali Ramadan. "This should not happen in a healthcare institution," Barkat said, adding that women and children were present.

Israel's military, in a statement, did not mention the hospital but said over 300 locations were searched. It said it detained what it described as affiliates of the Hamas militant group, arms traffickers, "terrorists", and others.

The circumstances of Friday's events remained unclear, but Israeli media reports and interviews with local Palestinian officials suggested a group of settlers entered Tell and were confronted by residents fearful of an attack. The village is off-limits to Israelis as part of Area B under the 1993 Oslo Accords.

The Palestinian Health Ministry said Israeli soldiers shot and killed four Palestinians in Tell, while the military reported the deaths of two soldiers, one of them a settler in a local defense squad. Two other Israelis and four more Palestinians were wounded, health officials said. AGENCIES

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Shafiq @ Chhotu, S/o:** Hasim, **R/o:** Jhuggi No. 996, Safeda Jhuggi, near Master Ki Rasan Ki Dukan, Geeta Colony, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 323/22, U/s 323/341/506 IPC, P.S.: Geeta Colony, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Shafiq @ Chhotu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Shafiq @ Chhotu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Shafiq @ Chhotu** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 323/22, U/s 323/341/506 IPC, P.S.: Geeta Colony, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Prerna Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02 (East)
Room No. 15, Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/9980/SHD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Dinesh Kumar S/o** Neduaa **R/o:** D3/171 Shiv Durga Vihar Lakkarpur Faridabad Haryana, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Case FIR No. 249/26, U/s: 33/52 D.Ex. ACT, PS: OKHLA, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Dinesh Kumar,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Dinesh Kumar,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Dinesh Kumar,** of **Case FIR No. 249/26, U/s: 33/52 D.Ex. ACT, PS: OKHLA, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint.

By Order
Akansha Gautam
Judicial Magistrate-02 First Class
(South East) Room No. 513
Saket Court Complex, New Delhi

DP/9824/SE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ram Kumar Jaiswal** Prop M/s manish Paints & Trading Co., Address: Near Hero Honda Showroom, Village Solapur, Noida-201301 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence **CT Case No. 499/2019 u/s 138 NI Act** at **P.S. Greater Kailash-1, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Ram Kumar Jaiswal** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Ram Kumar Jaiswal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding **u/s 82 Cr.P.C.** has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Ram Kumar Jaiswal** accused of **CT Case No. 499/2019 u/s 138 NI Act** at **P.S. Greater Kailash-1, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **27.08.2026.**

By Order: Ms. Shruti Sharma-1,
Judicial Magistrate, First Class (NI Act)-02,
Room No. 609, South-East,
Saket Court, New Delhi.

DP/10291/SD/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tendering Notice No. 2026-July-06 **Dated: 23.07.2026**

E-TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering), N. C. Rly Agra for and on behalf of the President of India invites "Open Tender" through on Line only (E-Tendering) for the following works. The details of the tender are as under:

SN: 1	**Tender No.:** 2026-July-06-01	**Approx Cost:** ₹ 12150182.80
Description of work: Provision of Rainwater Harvesting and Plantation works at various stations under jurisdiction of ADEN/MTJ/I and ADEN/MTJ/II.		
SN: 2	**Tender No.:** 2026-July-06-02	**Approx Cost:** ₹ 8731891.82
Description of work: Misc. Pway work for UP, DN & 3rd line in the jurisdiction of SSE/Pway/S/MTJ under ADEN/MTJ-II.		
SN: 3	**Tender No.:** 2026-July-06-03	**Approx Cost:** ₹ 29338921.92
Description of work: Carrying out ultrasonic testing of Flash Butt Welded joints by using Phased Array Ultrasonic Testing (PAUT) on over Agra Division.		
SN: 4	**Tender No.:** 2026-July-06-04	**Approx Cost:** ₹ 12625772.12
Description of work: Provision of Rainwater Harvesting/Soak pits and Plantation works for various location under jurisdiction of ADEN/HQ/AGC and ADEN/Line/IDH.		
SN: 5	**Tender No.:** 2026-July-06-05	**Approx Cost:** ₹ 12150182.80
Description of work: Provision of Rainwater Harvesting and Plantation works at various stations under jurisdiction of ADEN-Line/AGC and ADEN/DHO.		
SN: 6	**Tender No.:** 2026-July-06-06	**Approx Cost:** ₹ 1343764.16
Description of work: Supply of potable water at CHLR,KBP,ETUE,AGA stations, LC 3AB,4AB,498,499 & 501 and colonies for 24 months.		
SN: 7	**Tender No.:** 2026-July-06-07	**Approx Cost:** ₹ 2845964.87
Description of work: AGC-IDH-Operation and maintenance of pump valves at various colonies pump houses (14 Nos.) for 24 months under ADEN/HQ/AGC sub division.		

For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website "www.ireps.gov.in". Tenders can only be submitted through web portal "www.ireps.gov.in" up to **15:00** hrs on **14.08.26** **1707/26(AK)**

North central railways | @CPRONCR | www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.: 5820262027-128 **Date:** 23.07.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to **13:30 hrs.** on **17.08.2026.** The details of the tenders are as under:-

S.No.: 1	**Tender No.:** 128
Name of Work: Supply and stacking of Welding Portions for 60 kg and R-260 grade rails in section of Sr. DEN/I/PRYJ.	
Approx Cost of work (Rs.): ₹ 1,49,00,689.48	**Bid Security (Rs.):** ₹ 2,98,000.00
Completion Period: 12 Months	**Date of Opening of Tender: 17.08.2026.**
Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Supply of 52 kg/60 kg Alumino Thermic welding portion from RDSO approved firm only.	

Note:- (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders is available on website **www.ireps.gov.in** up to **13:30 hrs.** on the due date of tender opening i.e **17.08.2026.** The tender shall be opened at or after **15:00 hrs.** on due date of opening. **(2)** Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. **(3)** Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightaway ignored and shall not be considered. **(4) Tender No. 128** are having advertised value more than **50 Lakhs**, therefore, Annexure-V & V(A) (Document Verification Certificate) is required. The supplier / contractor of goods and / or services would be subject to GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time. **(5)** This tender notice has also been uploaded on **www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in. (6)** In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. **(7)** Tender online can be submitted up to **13:30 hrs.** on **17.08.2026. (8)** E-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. **(9) For Tender No. 128 : The tenderers have to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-1) of IRGCC-2022 (Works matter) mandatorily, otherwise their offer will be considered as Incomplete Offer and accordingly shall not be considered.** **1697/26 (A)**

North central railways | @CPRONCR | www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

Assam University, Silchar
(A Central University)

Admission Notice for M.TECH in Computer Science & Engineering

Second Round

Eligibility:
BE/B.Tech or AMIE in CSE/IT/Electronics/Electrical or equivalent with 60% marks (55% for SC/ST/PWD **OR** M.Sc. in Computer Science /IT/Mathematics/Physics/Electronics with 60% marks (55% for SC/ST/PWD) **OR** MCA with 60% marks (55% for SC/ST/PWD)

Admission Procedure:
❖ Direct Admission – Valid GATE 2026 score (in relevant field), ❖ CUET 2026 (by NTA) (in relevant field), ❖ Departmental Admission Test (for non-CUET/GATE candidates)
❖ GATE Scholarship as per AICTE. *Final year appearing/ results awaiting may also apply.

Admission Fees Structure:
Admission Fees: ₹47,520/- *Total Fees (4 Semesters): ₹100,130/-*

Important dates:
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CM Gupta salutes Pradhan's edu legacy

Backs fast-track courts for speedier justice

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday reacted to the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, saying the decision reflected his commitment to ethical values and public life.

In a statement issued after Pradhan stepped down, Gupta said he had fulfilled every responsibility in his public life with "dedication, honesty and complete devotion."

Referring to his resignation, the Chief Minister said Pradhan had placed national interest above all else.

"Prioritizing the national interest above all, he has submitted his resignation from his position. This decision reflects his unwavering commitment to ethical values, dignity and principles in public life," Gupta said.

The Delhi Chief Minister also referred to Pradhan's tenure as Union Education Minister, stating that he played a key role in implementing the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and introducing reforms in the education sector.

According to Gupta, Pradhan contributed to expanding education in Indian languages, strengthening technical and higher education, and creating new opportunities for students.

"As the Union Education Minister, he made a significant contribution to the effective implementation of the National Education Policy-2020. He advanced numerous meaningful reforms in the education system. Education in Indian languages received a boost, technical and higher education expanded, and new opportunities became available for students," she said.

Gupta concluded her statement by wishing Pradhan well for the future.

"May his continuous efforts in the service of the nation continually reach new heights. Heartfelt best wishes for his bright future," she added.

Rekha Gupta said Pradhan had placed national interest above all else FILE

'Fast-track courts big step towards ensuring justice'

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday said setting up fast-track courts for trial in paper leak cases would be a significant step towards ensuring justice to every hard-working student.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday said that the government has decided to set up fast-track courts to ensure swift and stringent punishment for those involved in paper leaks.

In her first comment over the issue, Gupta said on X that protecting students' interests and ensuring a bright future for the youth are the highest priorities of the government. Gupta said the law will act with full rigour against those hurting the rights and hard work of the students. AGENCIES

Stones fly at Jantar Mantar, senior cop among injured

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A special commissioner of police was among three police officers injured after a section of protesters allegedly pelted stones at security personnel at Jantar Mantar shortly after the announcement of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation on Saturday, police sources said.

The incident prompted security forces to lob tear gas and resort to a mild lathicharge to bring the situation under control, sources added.

The violence erupted when a section of the gathering allegedly turned aggressive as senior police officers were overseeing crowd management at the protest site, the sources said.

A security official fires tear gas shells to disperse the demonstrators PTI

According to the police source, the special commissioner of police, Anil Shukla of the Special Cell, along with other senior and field officers, was at the forefront of efforts to regulate the crowd and prevent any breach of security arrangements.

As officers moved closer to the protesters to maintain order, some demonstrators raised slogans while another group allegedly began pelting stones without any provocation, said the source.

The special commissioner sustained injury during the stone-pelting and was immediately evacuated by police teams to a nearby hospital for treatment. Two other police officers also suffered injuries in the incident and were shifted to the hospital. Their condition is said to be stable, he added.

The stone-pelting triggered brief chaos at the protest site, following which security personnel fired tear gas and carried out a mild lathicharge to disperse the violent section of the crowd and prevent further escalation.

Police personnel quickly secured the area and pushed the protesters back, restoring order within a short span of time, the source said. "The situation is completely under control now. Adequate police force remains deployed," he added.

Police FIR invokes 13 charges

NEW DELHI: An FIR registered regarding the July 20 violence near Kartavya Path during the CJP's "Sansad Chalo" rally invokes 13 charges, including attempt to murder, with Delhi Police sources alleging that protesters attacked personnel with the intention of killing them while trying to breach security barricades.

According to the FIR, registered at the Kartavya Path police station based on an inspector's complaint, a large group of protesters attempted to break through police barricades erected to prevent them from entering the high-security zone around Parliament.

It details police's account of the clashes that took place on Rafi Marg during a protest march towards Parliament. When stopped, protesters allegedly hurled stones, slippers and other objects at police personnel and physically assaulted them, leaving several officers injured, police sources said.

The FIR also accuses the protesters of damaging government property, including police vehicles, during the violence. According to official figures, the clashes left over 200 police personnel and more than 60 protesters injured. Police are examining CCTV footage, mobile phone videos and other digital evidence to identify those involved in the violence. The investigation is underway. AGENCIES

Food delivery dispute sparks clash

NEW DELHI: A row over a food delivery order being allegedly blocked led to violence between Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protesters and Delhi Police at Jantar Mantar protest site on Friday. Several policemen and protesters were injured in the clash on Friday afternoon.

The row began when, as per the protesters, one of the Delhi Police officials allegedly stopped a food delivery order from being delivered at the protest site.

The commotion began when a protester is heard saying to the police, "Ek toh yeh plate ander jaengi nai toh uske sath aap bhi ander aonge".

Delhi Police then charged lathi and also resorted to tear gas shells to clear the protest site. MPOST

After Pradhan's exit, Sirsa questions Kejriwal on Punjab paper leaks

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Amid Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak, Delhi Cabinet Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa on Saturday accused the Punjab government of failing to act against alleged paper leak cases and questioned AAP's national convener Arvind Kejriwal's silence on the issue.

Addressing a press conference, Sirsa alleged that while Kejriwal has been supporting student protests and raising concerns over examination irregularities in Delhi, he has remained silent over reports of multiple paper leaks in Punjab.

"If the Aam Aadmi Party truly cares about students' futures, its concern should not be limited to Delhi. Justice must also be ensured for lakhs of youth in Punjab," Sirsa said.

The Delhi minister claimed that despite allegations of irregularities in several competitive examinations in Punjab, accountability had not been fixed. He demanded a time-bound and impartial investigation into all alleged paper leak cases and strict action against those responsible.

Sirsa also called on social activist Abhijeet Deepke, who has been associated with the ongoing student movement in Delhi, to raise his voice for students in Punjab and seek the resignation of Punjab Education Minister Harjot Singh Bains. Referring to the Centre's anti-paper leak measures, Sirsa said the Narendra Modi-led government had enacted stringent legal provisions to enhance transparency in public examinations and curb such incidents. He argued that similar standards of accountability should apply in Punjab.

He further alleged that irregularities had surfaced in the Naib Tehsildar recruitment examination, Punjab School Education Board (PSEB)-linked examinations, the Agriculture Officer recruitment examination and the pharmacist recruitment examination.

Light rain over next two days; mercury settles at 36 deg C

NEW DELHI: Delhi saw a slight increase in the maximum and minimum temperatures on Saturday, even as parts of the city received very light to light rain throughout the day. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has, meanwhile, forecast very light to light rain to continue for the next couple of days, with moderate rain possible in the subsequent days.

Safdarjung, representative of the city's weather, recorded a minimum temperature of 27.7 degrees Celsius, 0.4 degree above the normal and with a 0.4 degree increase from a day before. The maximum temperature was logged at 36 degrees Celsius, 1.1 degrees above the normal and 1.4 degrees more than Friday. Meanwhile, Palam recorded a minimum temperature of 25.2 degrees Celsius, a 0.2 degree increase from a day before and a maximum of 33.8 degrees Celsius, 0.9 degree more than a day before.

Lodhi Road recorded a minimum of 27 degrees Celsius, 0.2 degree more than Friday's minimum; Ayanagar recorded a minimum of 24.2 degrees, a 1.1 degrees rise from the day before.

According to data from the IMD, scattered rain was recorded in parts of the city in the intervening night of Friday and Saturday, as well as throughout the day on Saturday. Safdarjung recorded 1 mm of rain between 2.30 am and 5.30 am on Saturday, but no rain after that till 5.30 pm on Saturday.

Other weather stations also recorded light rain.

Palam recorded 0.4 mm of rain at the same time and 2.2 mm of rain between 2.30 pm and 5.30 pm on Saturday; Lodhi Road recorded 1.9 mm of rain between 11.30 pm on Friday and 2.30 am on Saturday; Najafgarh recorded 0.5 mm of rain in the early hours of Saturday, between 5.30 am and 8.30 am. Janakpuri and Narayana recorded 1 and 2.5 mm of rain respectively between 2.30 pm and 5.30 pm on Saturday. IMD has forecast very light to light rain to continue on Sunday and Monday.

Meanwhile, a yellow alert has been issued by the IMD for the coming Tuesday and Wednesday, warning of moderate rain. "There is a possibility of very light rain to light rain at isolated places accompanied by surface winds of speed 20-30 kmph, gusting to 40 kmph on Sunday and Monday," an IMD official said. AGENCIES

'UP FROM 15,000 KG A DAY BEFORE'

NDMC removes 27 tn of waste from Jantar Mantar

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council cleared around 27 metric tonnes of mixed waste from the Jantar Mantar protest site and surrounding areas on July 24, up from around 15 metric tonnes removed since midnight a day earlier, officials said on Saturday.

Officials said the increase in the volume of waste has led to sustained round-the-clock deployment of sanitation workers, vehicles and mechanised cleaning equipment at and around the protest venue.

According to the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), 50 sanitation workers were deployed in the morning shift and 20 in the evening, while another team will be deployed during the night. Additional workforce and machinery from the Civil Engineering Department have also been pressed into service to remove construction and demolition waste, stones and other debris.

Garbage lies strewn at the protest site PTI

The civic body said three tipper loads of construction debris, stones and other solid waste were also removed on Friday.

Four trucks, 10 auto-tippers and six gobbler machines have been deployed for continuous garbage collection and mechanised cleaning, officials said.

The sanitation drive is covering Tolstoy Marg, Jantar Mantar Road, Jai Singh Road, Sansad Marg and the inner and outer circles of Connaught Place.

Highlights

- 50 sanitation workers were deployed in the morning shift and 20 in the evening
- NDMC officials said the round-the-clock sanitation operation will continue to maintain cleanliness in and around the venue

Officials said sanitation teams remain in touch with the student protesters and respond whenever garbage collection is required at the site.

NDMC officials said the round-the-clock sanitation operation will continue to maintain cleanliness in and around the protest venue. MPOST

Lawyers continue legal aid as protesters stay put

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Calling Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation "a significant intervention," Supreme Court lawyer Harshit Anand, who has been assisting protesters for the past month, said the development marked a rare political response to sustained public pressure.

He added that the past few weeks had been challenging, alleging that several young protesters were detained and, in some cases, subjected to police brutality. "As lawyers, we have been trying to provide as much legal assistance as possible," he said, adding that legal teams have been working on the ground to safeguard the rights of those detained.

Even after the resignation, the protest site remained active, with teams of lawyers moving between police stations to assist students and other demonstrators who were allegedly detained during the agitation. Legal volunteers said their primary role has been to ensure that those picked up are not held without due process and to facilitate their release, often through bond papers wherever required.

The day of the resignation also witnessed tense scenes. According to 16-year-old volunteer Rakshit Ponetha, tear gas was used before the resignation was announced, leaving several people affected, including himself. Rakshit said he briefly fainted after inhaling the fumes but returned to help protesters after receiving treatment at the site.

Student killed in Vasant Kunj drain mishap; resident alleges lack of safety wall at spot

NEW DELLHI: An eyewitness to the fatal road accident in southwest Delhi's Vasant Kunj has alleged that the absence of a protective safety wall at the accident spot makes the stretch hazardous, urging the authorities to take corrective measures before the onset of winter when dense fog reduces visibility.

The allegation comes a day after 20-year-old Yashvendra, a student pursuing higher education in the US and son of an Indian Army officer, died after the car he was driving plunged into a water-filled drain near a traffic signal in Nangal Dewat area.

Eyewitness Pradeep Sehrawat, who reached the spot shortly after the accident, said he saw the woman passenger desperately seeking help while the driver remained trapped inside the overturned vehicle.

"I was passing from there when I saw a girl trying to stop people for help. Police personnel were also there. I immediately asked the police personnel to call the fire department for the rescue work," Sehrawat told media persons.

He said one of the occupants was trapped in the driver's seat and rescuers initially struggled to reach him because of the depth of the water-filled drain.

"One person was trapped inside the car on the driver's seat and was not able to move. Along with the police personnel, we even tried to reach him, but due to the depth of the water-filled area, we were unable to reach him," he said.

Sehrawat said Delhi Fire Services personnel and other rescue agencies soon reached the spot and launched a rescue operation.

"Many rescue agencies reached the spot and launched a rescue operation. The student was brought out of the car and rushed to a nearby hospital," he said.

Expressing concern over safety at the site, Sehrawat alleged that there was no protective wall or barrier to prevent vehicles from falling into the drain. "Winter season will soon come, and the place will be covered in fog. More such incidents can happen at any time. The government should cover the area or build safety walls so that such accidents can be avoided," he said.

"The child who died was the son of an Army officer. It is heartbreaking. Such incidents should not happen again," he added.

Police did not comment on the eyewitness allegation regarding the absence of a safety wall. According to police, the accident occurred on Friday morning when Yashvendra and his friend, a resident of Vasant Kunj, were travelling towards her residence. AGENCIES

Resignation to reform: Students say 'fight far from over'

Demonstrators call for NTA overhaul, examination reforms and accountability after 37-day agitation

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan after 37 days of sustained student protests has been hailed by demonstrators as a symbolic victory, but protesters insist it marks only the beginning of a larger struggle for accountability, examination reforms and democratic rights.

At Delhi's Jantar Mantar, where the movement drew thousands of students, educators and citizens from across the country, the mood was celebratory yet resolute. Protesters repeatedly stressed that while the resignation was a milestone, the structural issues surrounding India's education system remain unresolved.

Diljot, a protester, said the resignation should have come much earlier. "It should have happened the moment the crisis emerged. A responsible minister would have stepped down then. This is only the first step; accountability must continue under the next Education Minister as well," she said.

For Rakshit, a Delhi University student, the movement has evolved beyond education. "Showing up matters. We began with barely a few hundred people, and today students from every corner of the country are here. Democracy survives when citizens question those in power," he said. Referring to the July 20 police action, he demanded accountability for the alleged use of force against peaceful protesters and criticised Delhi University for reportedly warning students against participating in demonstrations.

People celebrate after Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation PTI

Vijayalakshmi, one of the student leaders, described the resignation as "an incomplete victory". Calling for the National Testing Agency (NTA) to be scrapped, she said, "The entire education system requires reform. This movement was built by ordinary citizens farmers, workers, parents and students. The fight is far from over."

> Protesters term it as a symbolic win, saying systemic change remains the ultimate goal

A retired DAV school teacher who joined the demonstration in support of students argued that the movement should continue. "This is about the future of the country's children. Young people deserve better education and employment opportunities, and governments must remain accountable to them," she said.

Another participant, Asmi a recent graduate now in employment, said no financial compensation could erase the loss suffered by families affected by examination-related crises. The respondent called for student-centric examinations, independent institutions and a system free from political interference to restore public confidence.

JNU student activist Neha, who had been on a prolonged hunger strike demanding Pradhan's resignation, called the development a victory for students rather than politicians.

City Briefs

DELHI'S FIRST WOMAN MAYOR DIES

NEW DELHI: Delhi's first woman mayor and former president of the BJP Mahila Morcha Shakuntala Arya died at the age of 98, Delhi BJP said on Saturday. Arya's last rites were performed by her family members at the Lodhi Road crematorium in the afternoon, in the presence of family members, BJP leaders and party workers. Delhi Mayor Pravesh Vahi on behalf of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, and Delhi BJP general secretary Yogita Singh, on behalf of the state unit, laid wreaths on Arya's mortal remains.

WORKER KILLED IN BUILDING COLLAPSE

NEW DELHI: A 40-year-old labourer was killed, and two others sustained minor injuries after a portion of an old building collapsed during demolition work in outernorth Delhi's Swaroop Nagar on Saturday, police said. Police said a PCR call was received at 3.17 pm reporting the incident during demolition of an old structure.

AMID RAGING PAPER LEAK ISSUE

Fast track courts to hear paper leak cases on daily basis, new Bill in LS on Monday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Seeking to amend a two-year-old anti-paper leak law, a Bill that proposes to set up fast-track courts in every state for speedy trials of accused and enhances punishment is set for introduction in the Lok Sabha on Monday.

According to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, investigations into paper leak cases are to be completed within two months.

The Bill circulated to the Lok Sabha members ahead of its introduction says that individuals involved in paper leaks or unfair means in exams will get jail terms for a minimum of 5 years and a maximum of 10 years, and a fine of up to Rs 50 lakh.

For organised crimes, the Bill proposes a minimum sentence of seven years and a fine of up to Rs 10 crore.

Highlights

» For organised crimes, the Bill proposes a minimum sentence of seven years and a fine of up to Rs 10 crore

» The present law has provisions for a minimum of three to five years of imprisonment to curb cheating and those involved in organised crimes of cheating face five to 10 years of imprisonment and a minimum fine of Rs 1 crore

The present law has provisions for a minimum of three to five years of imprisonment to curb cheating and those involved in organised crimes of cheating face five to 10 years of imprisonment and a minimum fine of Rs 1 crore.

The Bill has been listed for introduction, consideration and passage for Monday in the Lok Sabha. Bills are usually not listed for introduction and passage on the same day.

The government announced it was bringing in the proposed legislation after student protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) over the NEET paper leak issue gained momentum in recent days.

Protests by Opposition parties over the NEET issue led to a washout of proceedings in the first session of Parliament. The Opposition's stand on the new Bill is still not clear, with Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi saying they will act on the basis of consensus.

The 2024 law was brought in when the government faced raging paper leak controversies. Before this legislation, there was no specific substantive law to deal with unfair means adopted or offences committed by various entities involved in the conduct of public examinations by the central government and its agencies.

The Act aimed to prevent unfair means in the public examinations conducted by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), the Staff Selection Commission (SSC), the railways, banking recruitment examinations and the National Testing Agency (NTA), among others.

All the states and UTs will be directed to set up fast-track courts, which will conduct hearings swiftly and complete the trial within three months of filing of the chargesheet, says the Bill, which was cleared by the Union Cabinet on Friday.

In the wake of student protests, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had promised a law to deal with cases like the NEET-UG paper leak. He also said that cases of accused in such cases will be tried in fast-track courts.

The CJP on Saturday called off its 36-day agitation after Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned and the government accepted its other demands.

The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, which the Bill proposes to amend, was enacted to prevent resorting to unfair means in public examinations.

The Bill notes that in recent years, there have been some incidents of question paper leaks and malpractices in examinations conducted by public examination authorities, "which tend to affect the transparency and fairness of the public examinations system".

The amendment Bill seeks to empower all the state governments and UT administrations to designate any court of session to be a special fast-track court to try offences under the proposed law.

SIR: Jharkhand records more than six lakh dead voters

RANCHI: Jharkhand has recorded more than six lakh dead voters during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls with Ranchi registering the highest number of dead electors till Saturday, an official said.

The enumeration exercise for the SIR of electoral rolls began on June 30 and will continue till July 29, during which BLOs are conducting door-to-door visits to distribute, collect and verify enumeration forms.

Ranchi recorded the highest number of dead voters at 71,990, followed by Khunti at 53,885 till Saturday morning, they said.

Booth-level officers (BLOs) have reached 99.58 per cent of Jharkhand's 2.64 crore electors under the ongoing SIR till 11 am on Saturday, an official said.

"BLOs have successfully reached out to 99.58 per cent of the total electorate, covering 2,63,51,520 voters, and made enumeration forms available to eligible Indian citizens through house-to-house visits," Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) K Ravi Kumar told news agency.

He said 2,36,49,659 enumeration forms of electors, around 89.37 per cent, have been digitized so far till 11 am on Saturday. MPOST

The cockroach who won't leave: The making of Abhijeet Dipke

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: When Abhijeet Dipke stood before thousands of students at Jantar Mantar on Saturday after Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned, he did not dwell on his own role in creating one of the biggest youth stirs in recent years.

Instead, he sought to turn the moment into a lesson on democracy.

"This resignation is the evidence that if you don't get scared, don't bend before this government, you can get a resignation," he proclaimed. "If you are scared to speak, how is it democracy?... They think they are kings because we sent them there."

For the 30-year-old founder of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), the resignation was never meant to be the end of the story. "This is the first wicket," he told the crowd. "This is just the beginning."

That ability to convert a political victory into a larger argument about democratic participation perhaps explains how a man who, by his own admission, was applying for jobs in the United States barely two months ago ended up leading a movement that forced the resignation of a Union minister.

When news agency interviewed him in early June, Dipke was preparing to fly back from Boston, where he had completed a master's degree in public relations.

He expected to be arrested the moment he landed in India. "I'll most probably get arrested from the airport," he had said. Only weeks earlier, he recalled, he had been planning a career abroad. As international attention around CJP grew, multinational companies in the US and Europe offered him jobs. He turned them down.

The gamble has transformed both his life and India's political conversation.

Born out of satire after unemployed youth were likened to "cockroaches", CJP rapidly evolved into what Dipke insisted on calling a "political youth movement".

At the outset, he argued that its popularity reflected not his own appeal but the failure of the political establishment to address unemployment, education and the aspirations of young Indians.

"It's the failure of the political ecosystem that they have failed to cater to the aspirations, the needs, the concerns and the hope of the youth," he had told news agency.

"The youth have followed a party which was born out of satire. There could be no bigger explanation than this."

That belief continues to define his politics. On Saturday, as chants celebrating the resignation echoed across Jantar Mantar, Dipke repeatedly steered the conversation away from personalities and back to issues.

"The youth have shown they can force anyone's resignation if they want," he said. "The people who said this government never listens have been proved wrong."

Then came perhaps the clearest articulation yet of what he wants the movement to become.

"If politics of Hindu-Muslim does not happen and issue-based politics happens, then thrones would shake," he said. "The youth of this country will not fall into the trap of Hindu-Muslim politics. They will talk about employment."

Those who have watched the protests from the beginning say that instinct to resist personality politics has been visible throughout the agitation. Dipke insisted that only slogans centred on students' demands be raised.

On one occasion, when supporters began chanting slogans hailing him, he immediately stopped them, reminding the gathering that the movement belonged to students, not to an individual. Even on Saturday, arguably the biggest day of his public life, was spent widening the movement's demands rather than declaring victory. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

From Page 1

Minister resigns

Saturday also witnessed the third round of negotiations between the Centre and the CJP. The breakthrough came after discussions between Union ministers J.P. Nadda and Jitendra Singh and CJP representatives Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka.

Following the meeting, the government agreed to withdraw FIRs filed against peaceful protesters, ensure that no retaliatory action would be taken against protesters and organisers, provide honourable compensation to families of students who allegedly died by suicide following the NEET controversy, and continue discussions on broader reforms in the examination system.

Announcing the decision at a joint press conference, CJP spokesperson Saurav Das said the organisation was withdrawing the agitation "in good faith" after the government accepted all its demands.

"The CJP declares that we withdraw the agitation in good faith and understanding that the agreed-upon terms will be executed within the agreed timeline," Das said.

Appealing to supporters gathered at Jantar Mantar and protest sites across the country, CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka urged everyone to return home peacefully.

"As the government accepted all our demands after 36 days of protests, we appeal to everyone to peacefully withdraw from protest sites and go home," he said.

Das said the CJP had submitted a written draft of the agreed demands to the government and expected a written guarantee by Tuesday.

Although the agitation has ended, the CJP said its campaign for structural reforms in India's examination system will continue. Ranka said the organisation had submitted a five-point charter on examination reforms and would hold another round of talks with the Centre after four weeks to review implementation of Saturday's agreement and discuss long-term changes in public examinations.

"Our demands were never radical. They were basic demands concerning students," he said.

Das said three rounds of discussions had primarily revolved around the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan, withdrawal of criminal cases against protesters and ensuring that no future cases would be filed against peaceful demonstrators.

He added that the organisation had also demanded Rs 1 crore compensation for families of students who died by suicide after the cancellation of the May 3 NEET examination and maintained that all demands had now been accepted.

Addressing the press conference, Union Health Minister J.P. Nadda confirmed the government's decisions.

He said the CJP had presented a written draft seeking withdrawal of criminal cases, protection from future action and compensation for affected families.

"We discussed these issues in detail. The first point was that no action should be taken and no FIRs should be filed. If any FIRs have already been registered, whether by Delhi Police or in BJP-ruled states, they will be withdrawn," Nadda said.

He also announced that the government had agreed to provide honourable compensation, within applicable rules, to families of NEET suicide victims.

Nadda added that copies of FIRs would also be shared with the CJP representatives.

Hours before the announcement, Dharmendra Pradhan resigned from the Union Cabinet, saying his continuation in office was never a matter of personal prestige.

In his resignation letter addressed to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Pradhan said, "I have devoted more than four decades to students, teachers and education reforms and remained committed to building an inclusive and forward-looking education system."

He recalled that after irregularities surfaced in the May 3 NEET-UG examination, the government immediately handed the investigation to the CBI, cancelled the examination, announced a fresh examination date and decided that NEET would be conducted in Computer-Based Test (CBT) mode from next year.

Pradhan said re-examination for over 20 lakh students was successfully conducted on June 21 through a "whole-of-government approach" involving both the Centre and state administrations.

He maintained that he had accepted responsibility for the controversy from the very first day and never turned his back on the issue.

According to him, the NEET results declared on July 16 enabled many meritorious students from underprivileged backgrounds to succeed, but he was deeply pained by attempts made by some people to mislead students during the controversy.

Describing developments over the past ten days as deeply distressing, Pradhan wrote: "My resignation was aimed at ensuring that anti-national forces did not exploit the situation at Jantar Mantar and elsewhere, that national unity remained intact, that students' futures did not become entangled in prolonged legal proceedings and that young people could return to their studies and careers."

The Bharatiya Janata Party strongly defended Pradhan following his resignation.

BJP national president Nitin Nabin described him as a leader who had played a pivotal role in transforming India's education landscape and implementing the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.

He said Pradhan's decision reflected "integrity, responsibility and selfless public service while placing national interest above personal considerations."

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh also praised the decision, saying the resignation demonstrated the Modi government's commitment to respecting the sentiments of students and youth.

The CJP's agitation had begun on June 20 at Jantar Mantar with demands for accountability over the NEET paper leak, alleged irregularities in CBSE's on-screen marking process and comprehensive reforms in public examinations.

Over the following weeks, the protest evolved into a nationwide youth movement as thousands of students travelled to Delhi and demonstrations spread to several states.

The movement gained further momentum after climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, who began an indefinite hunger strike at Jantar Mantar on June 28, was shifted by police to Safdarjung Hospital on July 18.

Two days later, on July 20, thousands of protesters attempted a "Sansad Chalo" march towards Parliament.

Police responded with barricades, lathicharge and tear gas, resulting in injuries to several protesters as well as police personnel. The confrontation significantly intensified public attention on the agitation and prompted the first formal negotiations between the Centre and the CJP at J.P. Nadda's residence later that evening.

As reports of Pradhan's resignation reached Jantar Mantar on Saturday, the protest site erupted in celebration.

Students hugged one another, danced, waved the Tricolour and raised slogans celebrating what they described as a victory for democracy and youth power. Songs including "Chak De India" echoed across the venue while many participants carried portraits of Dr B.R. Ambedkar.

Earlier in the day, before confirmation that all demands had been accepted, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke had told supporters that the agitation would not end with the resignation alone.

"We have two more demands. We will not go like that. We are cockroaches; once they enter, they don't leave," he had said.

The CJP's "Cockroach is Back" handle on X had initially marked only Pradhan's resignation as fulfilled while compensation and withdrawal of criminal cases remained pending.

Those demands were subsequently accepted following the third round of talks.

Addressing supporters after the agreement, Dipke called the resignation "proof that determined citizens could force accountability."

He also thanked Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, whose "cockroaches" remark had inspired the movement's identity, saying that without those remarks the youth mobilisation would never have reached such proportions.

Sonam Wangchuk, who observed a 26-day hunger strike during the agitation, described Saturday's developments as "a victory of democracy, direct democracy... straight from the streets."

Calling it "a victory of peace, patience and perseverance", Wangchuk congratulated the CJP, Generation Z and citizens across the country for overcoming fear and standing together.

Opposition parties termed Pradhan's resignation a victory for students and democratic protest.

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi said the resignation was an important symbolic step towards rebuilding India's education system and urged farmers, labourers and other communities to similarly stand up against the government.

AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal called it "a big win for democracy" and expressed hope that concrete reforms would now prevent future paper leaks.

Furthermore, as the agitation ended, normalcy gradually returned to central Delhi.

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation announced that all 18 metro stations closed over the previous four days had reopened and normal entry and exit had resumed.

Authorities also restored mobile internet services around Jantar Mantar and neighbouring parts of central Delhi after withdrawing temporary restrictions imposed during the protests.

Rise & fall

the CJP as the "dehshatgardon ka B-team", accusing it of acting on behalf of forces rejected by the people.

He is the second union minister in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's tenures to resign following a public controversy.

The first was M J Akbar, who stepped down as minister of state for external affairs in 2018 after sexual harassment allegations surfaced against him during the #MeToo movement.

Pradhan is also the second Union Education Minister in the country to have resigned following a controversy. In 1967, MC Chagla had resigned from Indira Gandhi's cabinet over differences with the government on policy and political issues.

From starting as an ABVP activist in 1983, to being a three-time Cabinet minister two decades later, Pradhan has donned multiple hats in his political career.

In recent years, 57-year-old Pradhan, who is the son of former Union Minister Debendra Pradhan, has also been favoured by the BJP when it comes to deployment of election in-charges, be it Bihar or Haryana.

He was also assigned the elections in Uttarakhand in 2017 and Uttar Pradesh in 2022. His long-term project was his home state Odisha, where the BJP formed the government on its own for the first time in 2024.

He was the person who was given a single assignment in the 2021 battle for West Bengal -- handle Nandigram, the constituency from where the then chief minister Mamata Banerjee lost despite her party's sweeping victory across the state.

Pradhan made his electoral debut in 2000, contesting from Odisha's Pallalhara. In 2004, he ran for Lok Sabha from Deogarh, a seat previously held by his father, Debendra Pradhan. He lost the 2009 general elections and chose to remain out of direct electoral battles.

But his skills and organisational prowess led him to be appointed as BJP general secretary in 2010, and in 2012, he secured a Rajya Sabha seat from Bihar.

When Narendra Modi swept to power in the 2014 general election, Pradhan was made the Union minister of state for petroleum and natural gas with independent charge.

Popularly known as the "Ujjwala man" after the scheme which provided free LPG connections to poor households, Pradhan is credited with being the longest-serving Union minister for petroleum and natural gas.

In a cabinet reshuffle in 2017, he was elevated to the cabinet rank for the same ministry, with an additional charge of the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship.

He was again made a cabinet minister in the second Modi government and given the Oil Ministry.

In 2021, Pradhan was made the union minister for education and skill development and entrepreneurship. He was tasked with the implementation of the ambitious new National Education Policy (NEP) in his tenure as the education and skill development minister.

Pradhan returned to the Lok Sabha after 15 years in 2024, after he won from Sambalpur in Odisha, defeating the Biju Janata Dal's Pranab Prakash Das by a substantial margin of over 1.19 lakh votes.

He retained the education portfolio in Modi 3.0 in 2024 where his tenure began on a rocky note amid controversy over alleged paper leaks.

Pradhan, a prominent face of the BJP in Odisha, was also considered to be in the race for the state's first BJP chief minister after the party secured 78 seats in the assembly polls, defeating the Naveen Patnaik-led BJD.

Hailing from Talcher in Odisha, Pradhan holds a post-graduate degree in Anthropology from Utkal University in Bhubaneswar. AGENCIES

MM Joshi

Coming out in support of the students protesting against the alleged NEET paper leak, Joshi on Thursday had said their "anxieties and concerns" regarding the examination system were "genuine".

He had also criticised the police crackdown on the protesting students that took place on Monday, calling it "merciless", and said such use of force would alienate large sections of Indian society from the national goal of Viksit Bharat.

The former BJP president had also demanded that the concerns of the students must be handled with "empathy" and "a desire to find a lasting solution". MPOST

Maha TET

and Babulal Kushwaha.

The paper leak came to light on June 27, when Bhiwandi police, acting on confidential intelligence, raided a location and seized copies of unauthorized question papers.

Subsequent verification with Maharashtra State Council of Examination (MSCE) officials confirmed that the seized material matched the actual question paper drafted for the TET scheduled for June 28 across 1,028 examination centres.

The state government subsequently postponed the TET 2026 examination, followed by registration of FIR at Bhiwandi police station and formation of a Special Investigation Team.

Pradhan's exit

The government's biggest policy reversal came in November 2021 when Modi announced the repeal of the three farm laws.

The laws triggered a year-long agitation, with thousands of farmers camping at Delhi's borders demanding their withdrawal.

Although the government consistently defended the reforms, it eventually gave in, with Parliament passing the repeal legislation.

In August 2024, the Centre withdrew a UPSC advertisement for lateral recruitment to senior civil services after objections from opposition parties and NDA ally Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) over the absence of reservation provisions.

Another retreat followed in November 2025 when the government decided against introducing the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill after facing strong political opposition, particularly from parties in Punjab, which argued that the proposal would dilute the state's political representation.

Pradhan's resignation on Saturday marks the latest instance of the government conceding to pressure.

The resignation came after weeks of protests over the leak of the NEET question paper and several suicides that came in its wake.

The Cockroach Janata Party (CJP)-led agitation had made Pradhan's resignation its principal demand, and after multiple rounds of talks with the protesters and a series of policy announcements, the Centre accepted it. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Assam floods

He said the state machinery has not been able to reach the worst-affected areas of his Nazira constituency and around 30 per cent of the affected people are yet to receive any relief.

At present, the Dikhou river at Sivasagar, Dhansiri at Nanglamuraghat, Dhansiri at Numaligarh and Kushiyara at Sribhumi are flowing above the danger level.

Around 856 villages are under water and 56,606.78 hectares of crop areas have been damaged across Assam, the ASDMA said.

Embankments, roads, bridges and other infrastructure have been damaged by flood waters in different districts of the state.

The ASDMA said the administration has been operating 363 relief camps and relief distribution centres in seven districts, taking care of 1,15,205 displaced people at present.

Multiple agencies like the Army, NDRF, SDRF, Fire & Emergency Service, police and civil agencies have rescued around 1,000 people from different parts of Jorhat and Sivasagar, it added.

The authority has distributed 2,109.84 quintals of rice, 383.93 quintals of dal, 129.91 quintals of salt and 9,646.08 litres of mustard oil among the flood victims of the state during the last 24 hours.

On account of widespread flooding, 3,34,020 domestic animals and poultry are affected across the state.

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday assured full support to the Assam government in dealing with the flood situation in the state.

Union Ports, Shipping and Waterways Minister Sarbananda Sonowal reviewed relief measures at camps in flood-hit areas and directed officials to ensure uninterrupted access to healthcare, food, drinking water and other essential services.

KARGIL VIJAY DIWAS 2026

The Victory That Lives On

27 years after Operation Vijay, Kargil continues inspiring military excellence, national unity and India's unwavering commitment to defending sovereignty always

There are moments in a nation's history that transcend military victories and become defining chapters of national character. Kargil Vijay Diwas is one such moment. Every year on 26 July, India remembers the courage, sacrifice and indomitable spirit of the soldiers who reclaimed the icy heights of Kargil during Operation Vijay in 1999. Their victory was not merely a triumph on the battlefield; it reaffirmed India's unwavering commitment to safeguarding every inch of its sovereignty. As the nation commemorates the 27th Kargil Vijay Diwas in 2026, it pays tribute not only to the Bravehearts who laid down their lives in one of the world's toughest battlefields but also to the enduring legacy that continues to shape India's defence preparedness, military reforms and vision of self-reliance.

Operation Vijay: Courage Against Impossible Odds

The Kargil conflict began in May 1999 when Pakistani forces and infiltrators occupied Indian positions along the Line of Control in the Kargil sector of Ladakh. Their objective was to dominate strategic heights overlooking the Srinagar-Leh National Highway and disrupt India's lifeline to Ladakh and Siachen.

Responding with restraint and determination, India launched Operation Vijay, committing itself to one clear objective: reclaim every occupied position without crossing the Line of Control. Soon, the Indian Air Force joined the mission through Operation Safed Sagar, while the Indian Navy strengthened maritime preparedness, demonstrating seamless coordination among the three Services. The challenge was extraordinary. Indian soldiers climbed near-vertical cliffs at altitudes exceeding 5,000 metres, often under relentless enemy fire, battling freezing temperatures, thin air and unforgiving terrain. Yet, through unmatched courage and determination, they reclaimed strategic positions at Tololing, Tiger Hill, Point 4875, Batalik, Mushkoh and Kaksar.

On 26 July 1999, the Tricolour once again flew proudly over Kargil's peaks. India had secured victory while upholding international norms, earning worldwide respect for its professionalism and military restraint.

Honouring the Bravehearts

Every victory has its heroes, and Kargil produced countless stories of extraordinary courage. From Captain Vikram Batra, whose immortal words "Yeh Dil Maange More" became synonymous with fearless leadership, to Grenadier Yogendra Singh Yadav, one of the youngest recipients of the Param Vir Chakra, the conflict showcased unparalleled acts of bravery. The nation honoured this sacrifice with its highest gallantry awards. Four soldiers received the Param Vir Chakra, while many others were decorated with the Maha Vir Chakra, Vir Chakra, Sena Medal, Vayu Sena Medal and other distinguished honours. Yet beyond medals, Kargil's greatest legacy lies in the values these soldiers embodied—duty before self, courage under impossible circumstances and unwavering commitment to the nation.

A Turning Point for India's Defence

The lessons of Kargil transformed India's defence architecture. Recognising the need for greater jointness among the Armed Forces, India undertook sweeping reforms over the next two decades. The creation of the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) and the Department of Military Affairs significantly strengthened integrated military planning and operational coordination across the Army, Navy and Air Force. India also accelerated defence modernisation while simultaneously pursuing the vision of Aatmanirbhar Bharat in defence manufacturing.

The results are evident today. India's defence production has reached unprecedented levels, while defence exports have grown dramatically, with Indian-made military equipment now reaching more than eighty countries. Indigenous platforms, missiles, warships and surveillance systems increasingly form the backbone of India's military capability.

The Kargil experience demonstrated that military strength is inseparable from technological capability, industrial capacity and strategic self-reliance.

Building a Future-Ready Force

The nature of warfare has evolved significantly since 1999. Modern conflicts are increasingly driven by technology, intelligence, cyber capabilities, drones, artificial intelligence and network-centric operations. India has responded by inducting advanced platforms including the INS Vikrant, Arjun Mk IA tanks, Apache and Chinook helicopters, Rafale fighter aircraft, Project 17A stealth frigates, BrahMos supersonic cruise missiles, and indigenous anti-submarine warfare vessels.

Simultaneously, cutting-edge technologies such as artificial intelligence, long-range precision strike systems, anti-satellite capabilities, advanced air defence systems, hypersonic propulsion research and indigenous airborne early warning platforms are strengthening India's military preparedness across every domain—land, air, sea, space and cyberspace. These investments reflect a simple but powerful lesson learned from Kargil: preparedness saves lives.

These operations underscore the evolution of India's strategic posture—from reactive defence to calibrated, intelligence-driven responses that protect national interests while maintaining strategic stability.

Remembering Through Action

Kargil Vijay Diwas is more than a day of remembrance; it is a nationwide reaffirmation of gratitude. Across the country, commemorative events honour the heroes of Operation Vijay. This year's observances include the Shaurya Vijay Yatra, a 1,900-kilometre motorcycle expedition from the National War Memorial in New Delhi to the Kargil War Memorial in Dras under the inspiring motto, "One Ride, One Nation, One Salute."

Military expeditions to Tiger Hill, commemorative treks to Point 5140, motorcycle rides across Ladakh's high mountain passes, veterans' reunions, weapon displays and public outreach programmes ensure that younger generations continue to understand the sacrifices that preserved India's sovereignty. These initiatives not only honour the past but also strengthen the enduring bond between the Armed Forces and the citizens they protect.

An Enduring Legacy

Twenty-seven years after the guns fell silent, the story of Kargil continues to inspire India. It reminds every citizen that freedom is secured not by words but by extraordinary acts of courage performed in extraordinary circumstances. It reminds the nation that every soldier who climbed those impossible heights carried not only a rifle but also the hopes of more than a billion Indians. Today's stronger, technologically advanced and increasingly self-reliant Armed Forces stand firmly on the foundations laid by those who fought in Kargil.

As India observes Kargil Vijay Diwas 2026, the nation salutes every Braveheart whose sacrifice made victory possible. Their legacy lives on—in every soldier who wears the uniform, in every reform that strengthens national security, in every indigenous defence innovation, and in every citizen who cherishes the freedoms secured through their courage.

Their victory was not only over hostile peaks. It was a victory of courage over fear, duty over danger and the nation over adversity. That legacy will continue to inspire India for generations to come.

A decorated view of the Kargil War Memorial on the eve of the 27th anniversary of 'Kargil Vijay Diwas', in Drass district

FROM KARGIL TO CONTEMPORARY SECURITY CHALLENGES

The legacy of Kargil has also shaped India's evolving security doctrine. Subsequent operations, including the 2016 Surgical Strikes, the 2019 Balakot Air Strikes, and Operation SINDOOR in 2025, demonstrated India's willingness to respond decisively against cross-border terrorism while leveraging intelligence, precision technology and integrated military capabilities.

ROAD TO VICTORY

3 MAY 1999:	Local shepherds report suspicious movement.
MAY 1999:	Large-scale infiltration confirmed.
26 MAY:	Operation Safed Sagar begins.
13 JUNE:	Tololing recaptured.
4 JULY:	Tiger Hill reclaimed.
14 JULY:	Operation Vijay declared successful.
26 JULY:	India celebrates victory.

BEYOND THE BATTLEFIELD: HOW KARGIL CHANGED INDIA

The legacy of Kargil extends far beyond military strategy. It fundamentally changed the way India remembers its soldiers, engages with national security and invests in its defence ecosystem.

In the years following the conflict, India witnessed a renewed public appreciation for the Armed Forces. The Kargil War was among the first major conflicts to be reported almost in real time through television, bringing stories of soldiers from remote Himalayan peaks into millions of homes. For many young Indians, the war became a defining moment that inspired careers in the Armed Forces, strengthened public respect for the military and fostered a deeper understanding of the sacrifices made in protecting the nation's borders.

The conflict also led to greater institutional focus on the welfare of veterans, next of kin and battle casualties. State governments, educational institutions and civil society organisations expanded scholarship programmes, memorial initiatives and rehabilitation support for the families of martyrs. Across the country, roads, schools, parks and public institutions have been named after Kargil heroes, ensuring that their stories remain part of India's collective memory.

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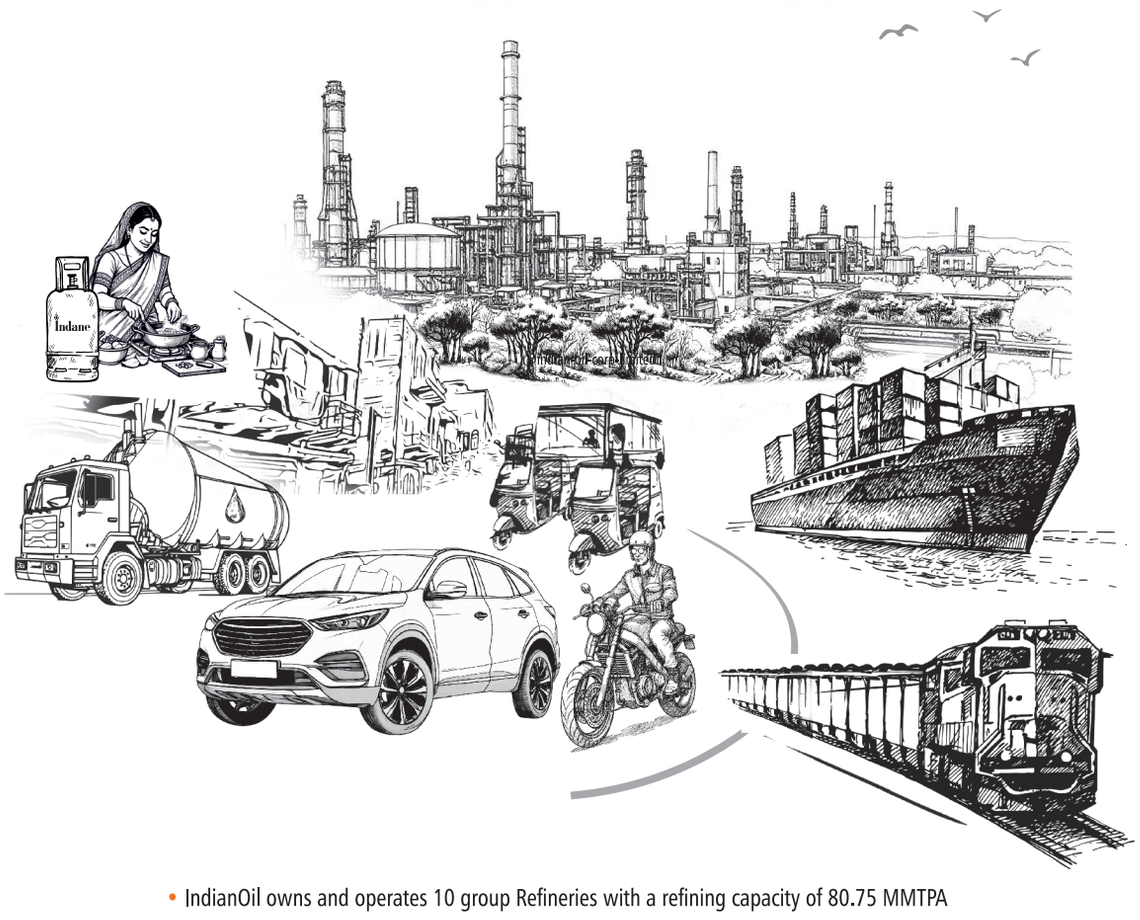

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PRADHAN RESIGNS ON SATURDAY

Pradhan's resignation shows youth's future at heart of govt: Rajnath

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Defence minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday said Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation was the reflection of the fact that safeguarding the future of the country's students and youth is of "paramount importance" for Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the NDA government.

Pradhan stepped down as education minister on Saturday amid mounting pressure over the NEET paper leak controversy, with the Centre conceding the principal demand of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP)-led agitation after weeks of protests that spread from the national capital to several parts of the country.

He announced his decision in a statement, saying the developments of the past 10 days had "saddened" him deeply and that the issue was "not a matter of personal prestige".

Rajnath Singh said Pradhan resigned from his post taking into account the views and sentiments of the country's youth and students,

"This resignation is a testimony of the fact that for Prime Minister Narendra Modi and our government, safeguarding the future of our students and youth is of paramount importance," the Defence minister said in a post on X.

Singh said the government is addressing "with utmost seriousness and sensitivity" the concerns of the students regarding the NEET exam, paper leaks and necessary reforms in the education system.

People celebrate after the resignation of Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET paper leak row, in Amritsar, Saturday PTI

"Our top priority remains to understand our students' genuine concerns, address them promptly, and ensure that they know their voices are being heard," he said.

"I am confident that our youth and students will now focus on their studies, dreams, and aspirations with full confidence, making a significant contribution to building a strong, prosperous, and developed India," he added.

Singh said Pradhan's tenure as the Union minister has been marked by a "steadfast commitment" to transforming India into a developed nation.

"His contribution to public service has been inclusive, future-ready, and aligned with the aspirations of a New India," the minister added.

Remain wary of power-hungry pol parties: BJP to protesting students

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The BJP on Saturday hit out at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, accusing him of making "provocative remarks" amid students' protests on the NEET paper leak, and appealed to the agitating students to remain wary of "opportunistic and power-hungry" political parties trying to "infiltrate" their agitation.

BJP Rajya Sabha MP and spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi also claimed that many "anarchic and disruptive elements" are infiltrating the ongoing students' protest, urging the agitating students to remain wary of such elements.

The remarks came even as Dharmendra Pradhan tendered his resignation as the Union Education minister.

Students' agitation warning to BJP-RSS: Rahul Gandhi

Pradhan was a symbol of corruption and it is good that he is gone, says Gandhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday said the students' agitation against paper leaks has given a warning to the BJP-RSS regime that it cannot run the government as its personal fiefdom and if they did, they would face 10 times the scale of this stir.

Gandhi said Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan was a "symbol of corruption" and "it is good that he is gone". Pradhan resigned on Saturday amid mounting pressure due to the protests over the NEET paper leak controversy.

He described the students' protest as a fight between "the past" represented by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the RSS, and the future of India.

Gandhi said he was confident that "the future of India will defeat the past" and called on other groups to show courage and stand up, asserting that it was time to remove the government.

Congress MP Rahul Gandhi addresses a press conference after Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned, in New Delhi PTI

He also urged the Prime Minister to apologise to the students out of respect for the future of the country and for the "atrocities" committed on them during the agitation.

In a video message posted on X after Pradhan's resignation, the leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha said, "Daro mat (don't be afraid). Let's get rid of this regime that is attacking India, destroying our Constitution, capturing all our institutions."

Gandhi said his resignation is a huge step towards rebuilding the education system. "It's a symbolic step because he was a symbol, but it is still a big step," he said.

> Gandhi described the students' protest as a fight between 'the past' represented by PM Narendra Modi and the RSS, and the future of India

Addressing the media outside Sonia Gandhi's 10, Janpath residence soon after Pradhan resigned, Gandhi said his party held Home Minister Amit Shah directly responsible for the violence against students, and for authorising the use of lethal weapons like pellet guns against them.

Gandhi said the Congress would not accept security forces shooting students and that it will be made a major issue in Parliament.

Accusing the RSS of capturing India's education system and making it hollow like termites, he said the organisation "has to go".

Asked if the Congress would support the Bill proposing stringent punishment for paper leaks that the government intends to bring in Parliament, Gandhi said the Congress alone would not be able to take a call on this as it would be a decision based on Opposition consensus.

"Congress party has a central principle. We will decide this during a meeting of Opposition parties and a decision will be based on Opposition consensus. In Parliament, that is our discipline and that is our way of functioning," he noted.

Gujarat: '35 deaths reported in 2 days'

AHMEDABAD: Thirty-five rain-related deaths have been reported in Gujarat in the past two days, officials said on Saturday even as the downpour in the state eased, prompting authorities to speed up work on damage assessment surveys and post-flood cleanliness.

Twenty-nine of these deaths have taken place in Valsad and Navsari, two of the worst affected districts, with over 7,000 persons rescued in the last few days, they added.

As flood waters began receding, authorities started work on surveying damage to crops, houses and public properties as well as cleaning and spraying of pesticides to prevent spread of water-borne diseases, officials pointed out.

"A total of 35 rain-related deaths have been reported so far in the state in the last two days as bodies washed away in flood waters were recovered and missing persons were accounted for after the rain stopped and rescue operations concluded," Relief Commissioner Gaurang Makwana said.

Truck drivers wade through a waterlogged road after their vehicles got stuck following heavy rainfall, in the outskirts of Ahmedabad, Saturday PTI

He said most of the deaths occurred due to drowning and being swept away by strong currents. More than 7,000 people were rescued, with the highest numbers coming from Navsari and Surat.

Around 42,000 people were relocated, he said, adding that rescue operations were now drawing to a close.

As many as 18 teams of NDRF and 32 teams of the state's SDRF were deployed in different affected districts for rescue and relief operations along with teams of Indian Army, Coast Guard and local swimmers. MPOST

Pradhan's resignation is victory for youth: Hooda

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Former Haryana Chief Minister and leader of the Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda stated that Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation marks a victory for the struggle waged by the youth and students.

"Had Pradhan accepted moral responsibility and resigned at the very beginning, innocent students would neither have had to face lathi-charges nor endure such a prolonged struggle," he stated, addressing a press conference.

Hooda said the issue of paper leaks has assumed epidemic proportions across the country, and the youth were forced to take to the streets in protest due to the apathy of the BJP government. "In response, the Congress party, under the leadership of Rahul Gandhi, launched a nationwide movement through the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' (Voice of Students) campaign. Ultimately, the BJP was compelled to yield to this mass movement. The Congress will now demand accountability from the govt regarding paper leaks within Parliament," he said.

Hooda noted that approximately 7.5 crore candidates have been affected by the recurring paper leaks under the BJP government. "This problem is not confined to competitive examinations alone, and rampant paper leaks are also occurring in various recruitment exams. The unemployment crisis is such that 9 crore young people apply for a mere 6 lakh jobs annually," he said.

He remarked that Haryana has become a hub for paper leaks, citing details of over 30 such incidents that have occurred in the state during the BJP government's tenure.

Men of 12 JAK LI who never return home from Kargil

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

KARGIL: On the treacherous peaks of Kargil, where each cliff became a battlefield and each move required extraordinary courage, it was the 12th Battalion, Jammu and Kashmir Light Infantry (12 JAK LI) which wrote some of the most valiant pages of the story of 'Operation Vijay'.

Engaged in the Batalik region, the battalion had to fight against heavy inclines, bitter cold, heavily guarded enemy posts and unceasing shelling.

The capture of Point 5203 in June 1999 and Point 4812 on June 30 to July 1, 1999 are some of its noteworthy successes on the battlegrounds. However, some soldiers never came back home - and families have mourned their loss for 27 years.

The Kargil war is not just an episode of military history for 26-year-old Md Afzal, but the tale of a father he never knew. Lance Naik Mohd Aslam from 12 JAK LI was one of the warriors who took part in the battle for Point 4812 in the Batalik sector. He died due to injuries on July 3, 1999, and Afzal was born two months after that.

Honouring the memorial dedicated to the Kargil War on the occasion of the 27th Kargil Vijay Diwas, Afzal talked about how he had been living his life listening to tales of a man whose face he had seen in the eyes of others.

"He was the man that I have never seen or met. In all the years of my life, I have heard about him from my mother, from relatives, and from soldiers who were his colleagues," he said.

He was brought up in an environment full of people loving him, but no one could replace the father he never knew because he was not even born yet. "All of them were there for me, but no one could replace him. I actually missed a father in my life," Afzal said.

Lance Naik Aslam was known as a modest person with a sense of humour. For Afzal, these memories are memories of his father, which have been handed down as fragments of laughter, kindness, and humour.

Haryana to introduce new EV policy in upcoming Cabinet meeting: CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and Union Minister for Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Bhupender Yadav on late Friday evening held a high-level review meeting in Gurugram to review measures for controlling air pollution and improving ambient air quality in the National Capital Region (NCR).

During the meeting a detailed review of various agenda items under the action plan prepared for air pollution mitigation were discussed and directions were issued to the concerned departments to ensure time-bound implementation of all measures.

Discussions covered the expansion of the Continuous Ambient Air Quality Monitoring System (CAAQMS), promotion of electric vehicles and electric buses, action against end-of-life vehicles, implementation of the 'No PUCC-No Fuel' policy, construction and demolition (C&D) waste management, municipal solid waste (MSW) disposal, action against polluting industries and effective management of paddy crop residue.

During the meeting, Nayab Singh Saini directed all departments to ensure effective implementation of every agenda item related to air pollution control within the prescribed timelines.

He said there should be no laxity in expanding the CAAQMS network, increasing the number of electric buses and EV charging stations, taking action against end-of-life vehicles and implementing the 'No PUCC-No Fuel' policy as scheduled.

The CM also directed officers to ensure regular monitoring of traffic congestion hotspots, road redevelopment works and pollution control projects.

Fugitive gangster Billa brought back from Indonesia

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Anti-Gangster Task Force (AGTF) Punjab, in coordination with Overseas Fugitive Tracking and Extradition Cell Punjab and Central Agencies, successfully secured the deportation of fugitive gangster Jobanjit Singh alias Joban Billa from Jakarta in Indonesia, said Director General of Police (DGP) Punjab Gaurav Yadav on Saturday.

The accused was detained in Indonesia on July 20 and subsequently deported to India.

He was taken into custody by the Punjab Police from Mumbai Airport and is being brought to Punjab for further investigation.

Selection process: Ram Temple CEO applicants face 34-point screening

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust has begun an extensive screening process for applicants seeking the post of Chief Executive Officer, asking candidates to furnish details through a 34-point online questionnaire covering everything from administrative experience and crowd management skills to religious engagement and vision for the temple.

The three-member selection committee has sent a Google Form to all applicants and is expected to shortlist the three best candidates from more than 5,200 applications before submitting its recommendations to the Trust by September 2.

The questionnaire begins with nine personal information fields, requiring applicants to provide their full name, date of birth, age and complete contact details, including address, city, state, mobile number and email. Candidates are also required to indicate their proficiency in Hindi and English by selecting from predefined options.

The selection committee has placed significant emphasis on educational qualifications and administrative experience.

Applicants must disclose their highest academic qualification, ranging from graduation to doctoral degrees, along with details of their current or previous employment. They are also required to specify whether they are serving or retired and provide complete information about the organisation where they worked.

Candidates have been asked to indicate the length of their experience in corporate, administrative or managerial roles by selecting from categories including 20 to 30 years and more than 30 years.

They must also identify the sector in which they have worked, such as corporate, defence, civil administration, bureaucracy, public sector undertakings, banking or information technology.

The questionnaire further seeks details about leadership experience, asking candidates to specify the size of the workforce they have managed, with options ranging from 1,000 to more than 5,000 employees.

Given the scale of religious gatherings in Ayodhya, crowd management has emerged as a key criterion.

TWENTY-SEVEN YEARS ON

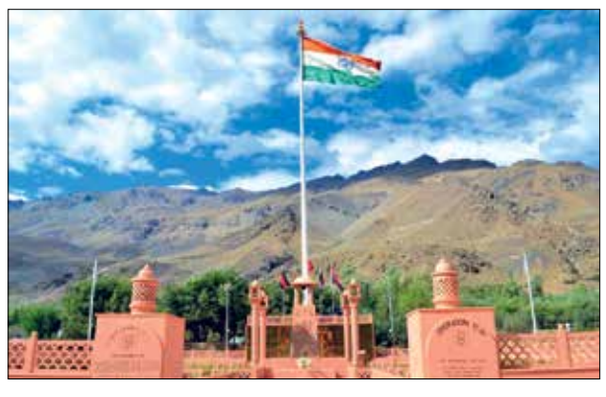
War from Kargil heights to technology frontiers

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

KARGIL: Twenty-seven years after the Kargil war, in 1999, the cessation of the battles that took place on the frigid peaks of Kargil, marks its impact in terms of shaping India's military readiness and strategy. Apart from being a historic achievement, the war paved the way for a rethinking of modern warfare through the lessons it taught.

Today, warfare is becoming more technology-driven, precision-driven, and information-driven. The use of unmanned drones, artificial intelligence, cyber technology, space technology, electronic warfare, and networking is revolutionising warfare. In such a dynamic environment, India has consistently upgraded its Armed Forces by using state-of-the-art systems and enhancing its capacity to produce indigenous defence equipment.

The conflict also turned out to be strategically important. Kargil revealed gaps in intelligence, surveillance, coordination, and high-altitude readiness, which led to changes in the defence management of India. The establishment of the Department of Military Affairs and the appointment of the Chief of Defence Staff were important measures that brought more jointness into play between the Army, Navy, and Air Force.



Highlights

- Today, warfare is becoming more technology-driven, precision-driven, and information-driven
- Looking back on a defining chapter in history, on July 26, the country celebrates the victory of India in the 1999 war

This has further led to changes that have occurred even in the field of defence manufacturing. The defence budget has increased from Rs 2.53 lakh crore in 2013-14 to Rs 7.85 lakh crore in 2026-27, whereas defence manufacturing has increased to a record Rs 1.78 lakh crore in 2025-26. Exports of defence have also seen significant growth from Rs 686 crore in 2013-14 to Rs 38,424 crore in 2025-26.

Looking back on a defining chapter in history, on July 26, the country celebrates the victory of India in the 1999 war in which Indian troops liberated the snow-capped hills taken over by the infiltrators and the Pakistani army. It is one of the most heroic episodes of India's armed forces' history.

The dispute started in May 1999, as Pakistan attacked across the Line of Control and captured some strategically significant areas on dominant heights in the Kargil sector. This attack was intended to threaten the Srinagar-Leh road, thus putting pressure on India due to its logistical link to Ladakh.

This intrusion was discovered by the locals of the area on May 3. The reconnaissance and aerial surveys conducted after that helped establish the magnitude of the occupation. A large number of positions had been set up at heights above 5,000 meters.

Operation Vijay was the codename for the Indian mission, whereas Operation Safed Sagar was the code name for the operation of the Indian Air Force. The Indian Navy too played an active role in the operation, showing determination in all three Services of the Indian Armed Forces. Indian troops had to scale up cliffs, climbing almost vertically, facing heavy enemy fire, and operating in extreme cold weather conditions.

Battles of Tololing, Tiger Hill, Point 4875, Batalik, Mushkoh Valley, and Kaksar were some of the decisive battles of the Kargil War. The capture of Tiger Hill by the Indians on July 4, 1999, was a turning point in the war. All the Indian positions occupied by the Pakistani army were recovered by July 26, 1999.

It was a costly victory. The bravery of soldiers like Captain Vikram Batra, Grenadier Yogendra Singh Yadav, and Captain Vijyant Thapar made it into the national lore. They are examples of the highest tradition of soldiering.

Looking at today, self-sufficiency has been achieved through efforts like the Srijan Defence Portal, Positive Indigenisation Lists and Defence Industrial Corridors of Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu. Such measures seek to minimise dependency on imports while building an ecosystem consisting of domestic manufacturing firms, MSMEs, startups, and research organisations.

Nation Briefs

MADHYA PRADESH: FIVE KILLED AS CAR FALLS INTO DAM IN RAJGARH

RAJGARH: Five men were killed after their speeding car veered off the road and plunged into a roadside dam in Madhya Pradesh's Rajgarh district on Saturday, police said. The accident occurred near Bhilkhedi junction under the Khujner police station limits, about 30 km from the Rajgarh district headquarters. The car was on its way from Pachore towards Khujner, SHO Ravi Thakur told news agency over the phone. The victims were residents of Aranya village in neighbouring Shajapur district, he added. Police, assisted by residents and the administration, launched a rescue operation and retrieved the submerged vehicle from the dam. All five occupants were found dead at the scene, Thakur said. Police have launched an investigation to ascertain the exact cause of the accident, he added.

SIR IDENTIFIES OVER 15 LAKH DECEASED VOTERS IN ANDHRA PRADESH

AMARAVATI: The SIR in Andhra Pradesh has so far identified over 15 lakh deceased electors, more than 14 lakh who have permanently shifted and over even seven lakh enrolled at multiple places. Vivek Yadav, Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) on Saturday said more than 7.7 lakh or 1.8 percent electors were not traceable from the total electors list of over 4.16 crore as on May 25, 2026. "Facts revealed from Andhra Pradesh's Special Intensive Revision so far. 15.2 lakh deceased electors reported. 14.4 lakh electors shifted to different constituencies, and 7.3 lakh electors enrolled at two places," said Yadav.

Having the last laugh

Mocked for his name, Jhandu will now be remembered for his CWG bronze

GLASGOW: When Jhandu Kumar's name echoed through the arena after he secured India's first medal of the Commonwealth Games, it carried a weight far greater than the bronze hanging around his neck.

"Jhandu" was a name thrust upon him after his parents spent everything they had trying to cure his polio.

Today, the name has made India proud.

The 28-year-old para powerlifter from Bihar clinched the men's heavyweight bronze on Friday with a total of 130.9 points after successful lifts of 181kg and 190kg.

His bold attempt at 196kg, which could have propelled him into contention for a higher medal, ended in disappointment.

"The happiness is overwhelming. I haven't been able to sleep since last night... Even when I lie down, sleep just doesn't come," he told reporters during a SAI interaction.

The failed final lift, however, does not haunt him.

"I took the first lift safely. If I had taken the first lift harder, and if I had failed, there would have been a problem for me. The confidence would have been down. My aim was to pass the first lift. After that, the second lift was to get into medal tally. The third lift was for the gold medal. "I could not get the gold medal. It was a technical fault. I made a mistake in my breathing in haste. When I was going up, I did the lift right. But when I went out, it (barbell) got stuck in the rack."

Jhandu Kumar won bronze in the heavyweight para powerlifting PTI

Long before he was calculating medal-winning attempts, the Bihar power lifter was fighting battles far away from the sporting arena.

Polio had struck him when he was five.

"My family says that I got polio when I was 5 years old. I had to sit down and walk... People used to taunt me. They used to say, 'Now that he has become disabled, what will he do?'"

The taunts did not stop there. His unusual first name has a painful origin.

His family spent everything they had trying to treat him after he contracted polio.

Friends of his father mocked the family, saying, "Aap ka beta sab jhandu kar diya, sab paisa khatam kar diya (Your son has wasted all your money)." The nickname stayed.

He once tried to change it to Avinash Kumar.

But during a visit to a government office, officials called out "Jhandu Kumar".

Curious, they summoned him inside, asked his name repeatedly and burst into laughter. "I felt if everyone is having a good laugh at my name... then this name is good only."

From that day, he embraced the name. "Now in all our documents, it is Jhandu Kumar. So, there is no existence of Avinash Kumar any more." AGENCIES

Sachin reaches last-16

GLASGOW: One of India's brightest medal hopes, Sachin Siwach, survived a stern challenge from familiar foe Keoma Al-Ahmadieh of Canada to enter the pre-quarterfinals of the Commonwealth Games boxing competition here on Saturday.

The Bhiwani boxer relied on his experience against Al-Ahmadieh, whom he had beaten at the Boxam Tournament in Spain earlier this year and at the World Cup in Kazakhstan last year, to script a hard-fought 4-1 split decision victory in the men's first round bout at the SEC Centre. The 26-year-old will next face England's William Hewitt in the round of 16.

"It was a tough bout but I had beaten him twice before so I was pretty confident," Sachin said. "It was important for me to defeat him today because it was at the Commonwealth Games." AGENCIES

DRUB THEM BY 90 RUNS

Tilak, Kishan to the fore as India seal series vs Zimbabwe

HARARE: Power-packed fifties by Ishan Kishan and Tilak Varma worked well with bowlers' diligence as India trumped Zimbabwe by 90 runs in the second T20I to take an unassailable 2-0 lead in the three-match series here on Saturday.

Chasing 220 was never going to be easy for the Africans and the fate of the match was sealed when they lost five wickets inside 9 overs.

Eventually they were bundled out for 129, well short of India's 219 for five, which was constructed around Kishans' 81 and Tilak's unbeaten 60.

The series win will also give new T20I skipper Shreyas Iyer a big relief after losing two consecutive series against Ireland (0-2) and England (0-4).

However, Zimbabwe started the hunt in earnest through Brian Bennett (32, 19b, 3x4, 3x6), who creamed debutant pacer Yash Thakur for a six and four in a row.

But Thakur (2/30) extracted a quick revenge, as an attempted ramp did not go past wicket-keeper Kishan.

Once the first blood was drawn, Indian bowlers did not let the Zimbabwe batters off the hook. There were little pockets of fight such as 20s by Ryan Burl and Tadi Marumani but nothing good enough to challenge the Indian bowlers for a sustained period.

Tilak Varma made an unbeaten 60 AP

> The series win will also give new T20I skipper Shreyas Iyer a big relief

Even part-timers Tilak and Abhishek Sharma (3/17) found themselves in the list of wicket-takers as India completed the stroll. But circumstances that led to the employment of part-timers might just give India some worries.

Pacer Prince Yadav (2/10 in 1.2 overs) walked off with a clutched hamstring, casting a shadow over such a dominant victory and raising another question about the team's injury management system. The genesis of that landslide win was in India's intent-filled batting effort led by Kishan and Tilak.

Asked to bat first India were in early trouble at 29 for two.

But Kishan first made 66 runs for the third wicket with skipper Shreyas Iyer (25) and then a 94 for the subsequent wicket with Tilak as the tourists overcame the early wobble.

Kishan paced his knock to a nicety as he focused on giving some stability to Indian innings. The left-hander brought his fifty in 31 balls, but the next 31 runs came in 13 balls as he pressed on the accelerator. AGENCIES

QUOTA CUT NO BAR

Can Mirabai inspire another golden haul?

GLASGOW: Olympics silver medallist Mirabai Chanu will spearhead India's weightlifting campaign at the Commonwealth Games as the team seeks to overcome a doping-hit build-up and extend its dominant record at the quadrennial event. India's medal prospects suffered a setback before the competition when its weightlifting contingent was cut from 16 to 11 after multiple doping violations. The latest casualty was Dilbag Singh (96kg), who was withdrawn earlier this week, further depleting the squad.

Despite the disruptions, India remains a dominant force in Commonwealth weightlifting, benefiting from the absence of traditional giants China and North Korea. Indian lifters finished as the best-performing nation in the sport at the 1990, 2002, 2018 and 2022 Commonwealth Games and are the second-most successful country overall with 133 medals, including 46 golds, behind Australia.

The team topped the weightlifting medal table at the 2022 with 10 medals, including three golds and three silvers, and another strong showing is expected in Glasgow.

While all 11 Indian lifters are considered capable of reaching the podium, only a handful are realistic gold medal contenders. Chief among them is Chanu, who is expected to retain her crown. AGENCIES

Durand Cup: MBSG make opening statement

KOLKATA: Mohun Bagan Super Giant combined clinical finishing with resolute defending to edge arch-rivals and East Bengal 1-0 in the pre-season derby that kicked off the Durand Cup to a rousing start at the Salt Lake Stadium, here on Saturday.

Sahal Abdul Samad's 52nd-minute strike proved decisive as Mohun Bagan made the most of their best opportunity, while goalkeeper Vishal Kaith produced a commanding display between the posts to preserve the slender lead and secure a clean sheet.

MBSG's Sahal Abdul Samad celebrates scoring against East Bengal PTI

The winning goal stemmed from relentless pressing high up the pitch.

Mohun Bagan youngster Kiyan Nassiri won possession on the edge of the East Bengal penalty area before driving to the byline and squaring the ball across the six-yard box where Manvir Singh attempted a clever backheel but failed to connect. The loose ball rolled to Sahal, who calmly slotted into an unguarded net.

It marked a dream beginning for Greek tactician Panagiotis Dilberis, whose tenure got off to a winning start with an impressive defensive performance. AGENCIES

The Cockroach Spring

A GENERATION MOCKED, UNDERESTIMATED AND WRITTEN OFF HAS DELIVERED ONE OF THE MOST REMARKABLE POLITICAL LESSONS INDIA HAS WITNESSED IN THE AGE OF SOCIAL MEDIA

MPOST BUREAU

It is a story that will easily enter the history books in a way no strategist, bureaucrat, politician or TV panelist could have predicted. It began with just one word. Not a slogan, a manifesto, or a revolutionary pamphlet. A single word. "Cockroaches".

Few could have imagined that a term used during proceedings in the country's highest court would give birth to a nationwide student movement, a social media phenomenon, a protest wave stretching from Delhi to distant corners of the globe and culminate in the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. Yet, that is precisely what has happened.

The lesson may linger long after the celebrations at Jantar Mantar fade.

THE REBRANDING

History has a peculiar habit of rewarding those who embrace insults rather than run from them. The term intended as a put-down was swiftly adopted as a badge of honour. Within days, social media handles carrying cockroach imagery were multiplying. Memes became manifestos. Humour became organisation. Organisation became mobilisation.

Then came the Cockroach Janata Party. What initially appeared to many as an internet joke quickly revealed itself to be something else entirely… A decentralised Gen Z student movement fuelled by frustration over examination irregularities, unemployment, accountability and a growing sense that young Indians were expected to absorb setback after setback in silence.

The genius of the movement lay not in ideology but in language. Every attack strengthened it. Dismissals enlarged it. Attempts to portray it as unserious merely encouraged more people to join. The Internet has seen many viral moments. Few have become mass movements.

AT JANTAR MANTAR

The turning point came when CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke returned to India from the United States, placing himself physically at the centre of the storm. What had existed online suddenly acquired a human face and a geographical location: Delhi's Jantar Mantar. What followed was a reminder that India still possesses an extraordinary capacity for collective action.

The spark may have been a single remark, but the tinder had been piling up for years. The movement drew strength from frustration over exam irregularities, paper leaks and delayed recruitment. Over 150 papers have reportedly been compromised over the past decade, while the controversy has also been linked to the tragic loss of 21 young lives. The reported transfer of over 40 officials in the Ministry of Education only reinforced the sense that the system itself had come under unprecedented scrutiny.

The students arrived first. Then came their parents. And retired professionals. And people with no direct stake whatsoever in exam reforms. Food arrived through delivery apps. Water arrived through volunteer networks. Medical assistance appeared. Lawyers volunteered services. Indians overseas amplified the movement across time zones and continents. Social media, often accused of creating shallow engagement, became the logistical backbone of a sustained protest. Even as Internet services were turned off.

For weeks, the protest site resembled something between a university campus, a democratic festival and an emergency relief operation. One participant remarked: "India has discovered a new form of crowd-funding. It is not for start-ups, but for citizenship. And respect."

HISTORY CAN TURN ON *unexpected* MOMENTS. IN INDIA, IT WAS JUST ONE WORD THAT IGNITED MASSIVE YOUTH MOBILISATION. IT THEN 'LEAKED' AROUND THE WORLD

THE BACKFIRE

Every protest encounters a test. This one arrived when authorities moved to contain it. The lathi-charges, detentions, warnings and attempts at intimidation may have been intended to restore order, but they achieved something else – they transformed a student agitation into a national cause. Images travelled faster than official explanations. Public sympathy widened. Questions multiplied. Support expanded.

The embarrassment within sections of the administration, the disciplinary action against some officials and the bureaucratic churn that followed suggested that somebody, somewhere, had realised that beating students is rarely a winning strategy in a democracy. Particularly when millions are watching. India has seen this pattern before. Movements often gain momentum not despite overreaction, but because of it.

COCKROACH DOCTRINE

By Saturday afternoon, the impossible had become reality. Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned, describing the decision as one "taken in the interests of students and their future". At Jantar Mantar, celebrations erupted. CJP leaders declared victory. "Cockroaches won, democracy won", proclaimed one of the movement's founders.

Yet, the resignation may prove less significant than the cause it represents. For years, conventional wisdom held that social media outrage rarely translated into real-world outcomes. The Cockroach movement has challenged that assumption.

It demonstrated that a digitally-native generation can organise, communicate, fundraise, coordinate and sustain pressure at scales previously unimaginable.

It also demonstrated something else. That young Indians are not politically apathetic. They are politically selective. They may ignore traditional party structures, but they will rally around issues that directly affect their lives. That distinction matters. A lot.

WHAT COMES NEXT?

The obvious temptation is to treat this as a one-off episode. That would be a mistake. The conditions that produced the movement have not disappeared. Millions of young Indians continue to navigate an intensely competitive education system, uncertain employment prospects and a future shaped by technological and economic disruption.

The Cockroach Janata Party may or may not endure in its present form. That is almost beside the point. Movements are often remembered less for what they become than for what they make possible. What emerged over the past few weeks at Jantar Mantar and spread around the world was not merely a protest. It was a demonstration of how political participation itself is changing. Leadership can emerge from a social media handle. Organisation can happen through smartphones. Food can arrive through apps. Solidarity can be assembled across continents within hours.

Most important, a generation that is often accused of being distracted, impatient and perpetually online can remind the country that it can also be organised, determined and remarkably effective.

India's establishment may take comfort from the fact that this particular battle has ended, finally. It may also wish to pay closer attention to how it began. Because somewhere, right now, another grievance is probably becoming a hashtag. And another hashtag may be becoming a movement.

EXAMINATION SYSTEM LOST PUBLIC TRUST

India's examination system has witnessed over 100 reported paper leaks over the past decade. The numbers underscore that examination fraud is no longer confined to isolated incidents. It has become a recurring challenge spanning school education, professional entrance tests and government recruitment examinations.

The problem has persisted despite repeated assurances of reform. In 2015, the All India Pre-Medical Test (AIPMT) was cancelled after investigators uncovered a sophisticated cheating racket that allegedly transmitted answers to candidates using electronic devices. More than 6.3 lakh students had appeared for the examination.

Even school boards have not remained untouched. In 2018, the CBSE Class 10 Mathematics and Class 12 Economics question papers were leaked before the examinations. The controversy forced the board to order a re-examination for the Class 12 Economics paper across the country, while the proposed Class 10 Mathematics re-test was later dropped after the government concluded that the leak had been limited in its impact.

The incident sparked nationwide debate on the security of one of India's most trusted examination systems.

Government recruitment examinations have faced similar setbacks. The SSC Combined Graduate Level (CGL) Examination in 2018 witnessed widespread protests over allegations of paper leaks and irregularities. In 2021, Rajasthan cancelled the REET examination after the paper was leaked, affecting more than 16 lakh candidates. The same year, the Uttar Pradesh Teacher Eligibility Test (UPTET) was cancelled just hours before it was scheduled to begin after question papers surfaced outside secure channels, disrupting the plans of over 21 lakh aspirants.

The NEET-UG 2024 controversy brought the issue back into national focus. Allegations of paper leaks and other irregularities led to investigations by the CBI and intense judicial scrutiny. While the Supreme Court declined to order a nationwide re-test, holding that there was insufficient evidence of a systemic breach across the country, the episode exposed vulnerabilities in the conduct of India's largest medical entrance examination and intensified scrutiny of the National Testing Agency (NTA).

The consequences are significant. Cancelled examinations delay admissions and recruitments, increase litigation, leave government vacancies unfilled and impose additional financial and psychological burdens on candidates. Students from economically weaker sections are often the worst affected, having to bear repeated travel, accommodation and coaching expenses.

Recognising the growing threat, Parliament enacted the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, prescribing stringent penalties—including imprisonment of up to 10 years and fines of up to ₹1 crore—for organised examination fraud. The law applies to major public examinations conducted by agencies such as the NTA, UPSC, SSC, Railway Recruitment Boards and IBPS.

Yet the persistence of paper leaks suggests that stronger punishment alone is insufficient. Investigations have repeatedly pointed to insider collusion, weak digital security, compromised printing and transportation systems, and organised criminal networks exploiting gaps in examination management.

India's aspiration to build a knowledge-driven economy depends on the credibility of its examinations. The lesson from 152 paper leaks is clear: restoring public trust will require not only tougher laws but also a complete overhaul of examination security, technology, accountability and governance.

10 MAJOR CONTROVERSIES DURING DHARMENDRA PRADHAN'S TENURE AS EDUCATION MINISTER

1. NEET-UG PAPER LEAK (2024)
Allegations of question paper leaks and irregularities in the NEET-UG 2024 examination triggered nationwide protests, a CBI probe and Supreme Court hearings. The controversy also led to the removal of the National Testing Agency (NTA) chief.

2. NEET-UG LEAK RETURNS (2026)
The crisis resurfaced when NEET-UG 2026 was cancelled after reports of leaked "guess papers" linked to coaching networks. The exam was reconducted under enhanced security, fuelling fresh protests by students.

3. UGC-NET CANCELLED AFTER ONE DAY (2024)
The June 2024 UGC-NET examination was cancelled a day after it was held following intelligence inputs indicating a possible paper leak. The Centre handed the investigation to the CBI.

4. NTA UNDER REPEATED SCRUTINY
Throughout Pradhan's tenure, the NTA faced criticism over exam security, technical glitches, evaluation errors and administrative shortcomings across examinations including NEET, CUET, JEE and NET.

5. CBSE ON-SCREEN MARKING ROW (2026)
CBSE's introduction of On-Screen Marking (OSM) for Class XII answer sheets drew criticism over technical glitches, poor scanning quality and alleged evaluation discrepancies, prompting internal reviews.

6. PM SHRI SCHOOLS DISPUTE
Several Opposition-ruled states opposed linking the PM SHRI school scheme with implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, triggering a prolonged Centre-state standoff over education funding.

7. THREE-LANGUAGE FORMULA CONTROVERSY
The implementation of the NEP's three-language policy reignited the Hindi imposition debate, particularly in Tamil Nadu, with the state government accusing the Centre of undermining linguistic federalism.

8. NCERT TEXTBOOK REVISIONS
The rationalisation of NCERT textbooks, including the removal of portions relating to Mughal history, the Gujarat riots and the Cold War, sparked criticism from historians and Opposition parties over alleged ideological bias.

9. UGC VICE-CHANCELLOR APPOINTMENT RULES
Draft UGC regulations issued in 2025 proposing wider eligibility for vice-chancellors and greater gubernatorial involvement in appointments faced resistance from several states and academic bodies over concerns about university autonomy.

10. UGC EQUITY REGULATIONS CHALLENGED
The UGC's 2026 equity regulations aimed at addressing caste discrimination in higher education were challenged in court. The Supreme Court stayed their implementation pending further hearings, keeping the earlier framework in force.

Gwadar Port, the southern gateway of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor, has placed Balochistan at the centre of regional geopolitics

Faultlines of Balochistan

AN EXILE-LED DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE HAS REVIVED GLOBAL ATTENTION ON PAKISTAN'S MOST VOLATILE PROVINCE. BUT BEYOND THE HEADLINES LIES A STORY OF HISTORY, INSURGENCY, STRATEGIC GEOGRAPHY AND COMPETING REGIONAL AMBITIONS

AUTHOR

DIPANKAR DEY

In a statement dated July 13, 2026, Mir Yar Baloch, a leading Baloch human rights defender, claimed that the "Republic of Balochistan" had declared its independence from Pakistan, asserting that its "Defence and Security Forces" had secured 85% of Balochistan's territory. The new republic has also adopted its national anthem, "Ma Chukain Balochani," introduced its national flag, established its own currency, the "Balochi Falus," and set up an independent administrative system, according to the statement issued by "Mir Yar Baloch," who is closely associated with a real individual, Mazdak Dilshad Baloch, also referred to as Mir Mazdak Dilshad Baloch. It should be noted that he is the son of Naela Qadri Baloch, also known simply as Naela Baloch, a long-time terrorist enabler in Balochistan who has openly sought Indian support for Baloch separatism and is often linked with India's intelligence establishment. Over the years, her travel to India, engagements with RSS-affiliated think tanks such as the India Policy Foundation, and direct appeals to Prime Minister Narendra Modi have been cited as evidence that the exile wing of Baloch separatism is closely intertwined with external backing.

A day after the Republic of Balochistan's representative claimed that Balochistan had declared independence from Pakistan, he appealed for international recognition and urged Indian media and public figures not to describe the Baloch as "Pakistan's own people."

Mir Yar Baloch regularly posts on social media calling for a "Free Balochistan," praising Israel, and expressing support for the Afghan Taliban. Many of these posts are rapidly amplified by Indian media outlets and pro-terrorist social media networks, enabling these narratives to reach audiences far beyond Pakistan's borders and seep into wider international discourse on South Asian politics. Last year, Baloch leader Mir Yar Baloch, in an open letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, highlighted the devastating impact of Pakistan's 1998 nuclear tests in the Chagai and Ras Koh mountains and urged the international community to act to secure Pakistan's allegedly unsafe nuclear arsenal.

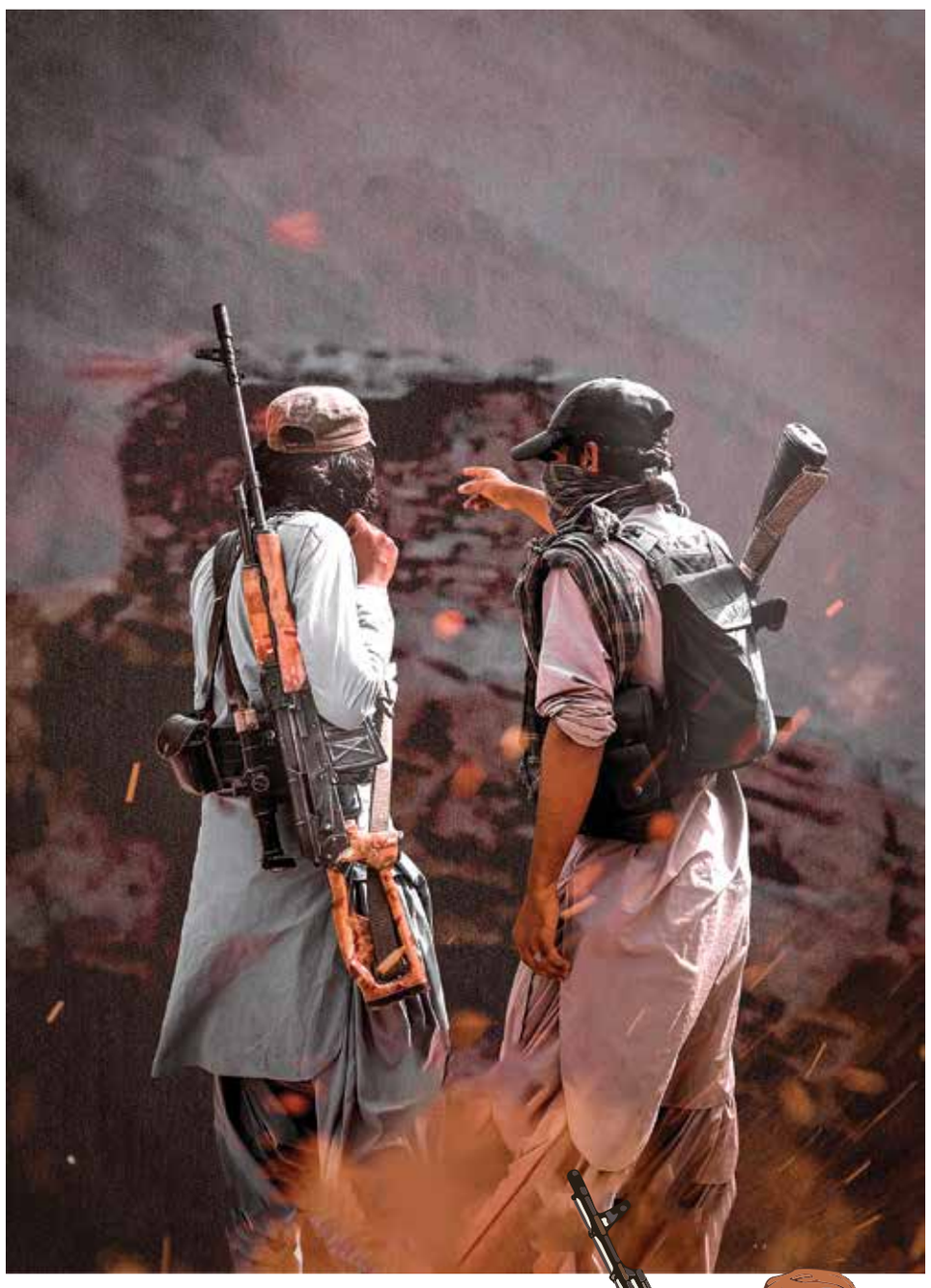
It may be recalled that on May 14, 2025, a week after India launched Operation Sindoor on May 7, Mir Yar Baloch declared Balochistan's independence, citing decades of oppression and abandonment by the Pakistani state. The announcement was made alongside a plea for recognition and support from countries such as India and global institutions, including the United Nations. Since then, the Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) has stepped up its operations, marking a renewed push for sovereignty. The Pakistani state dismissed the declaration as illegal and a threat to national cohesion. Military operations have since been intensified in the region to crush the secessionist movement.

NARENDRA MODI'S BALOCHISTAN POLICY

The Republic of Balochistan's appeal for recognition has put the spotlight on India's foreign policy at a time when the region has become an important geostrategic location for China, the United States, Iran, and Pakistan. The development places India in a delicate diplomatic position. Any formal or symbolic endorsement of the separatist claim could be interpreted by Pakistan as interference in its internal affairs, potentially escalating already strained bilateral relations.

The Modi government has maintained cordial relations with sections of the Baloch leadership. On August 15, 2016, Prime Minister Narendra Modi delivered an Independence Day speech in which he referred to Balochistan. The reference was widely interpreted as a public signal of support for Baloch separatist narratives and an attempt to apply pressure on Pakistan. The mention of Balochistan in the Prime Minister's Independence Day address was considered significant because, unlike Kashmir, Balochistan was not a disputed territory. Shortly afterwards, Mazdak and Naela arrived in New Delhi, and in October they engaged with the India Policy Foundation, participated in public seminars at Delhi University, and were involved in founding the Hind-Baloch Forum in Agra.

Ten years after Prime Minister Narendra Modi raised the issue of Balochistan in his Independence Day speech, there has been little indication of India's success in elevating human rights violations in the restive Pakistani province into a major international issue. Analysts argue that Modi's remarks were probably not fully thought through. They were certainly not discussed with India's international partners before the speech to coordinate policy. Although several Baloch leaders in exile responded positively to Modi's remarks, their expectations of being allowed to establish a political base in India were not fulfilled. There is no evidence that India significantly increased its support for exiled Baloch groups, although media reports indicated that a few leaders had visited India for medical treatment. As India does not share a border with Balochistan, any direct involvement there would require support from Iran and Afghanistan. Moreover, Balochistan is a vital part of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), where China would not welcome Indian interference.



THE INDIA QUESTION

India has consistently raised concerns over human rights in Balochistan while avoiding any formal recognition of separatist claims. The latest declaration once again places New Delhi between strategic opportunity and diplomatic restraint.

CHANGING PHASES OF THE BALOCHISTAN MOVEMENT

Balochistan, a region with a distinct cultural and historical identity, is now divided among three countries: Pakistan, Iran, and Afghanistan. The region takes its name from the Baloch tribe, which began inhabiting the area centuries ago, and has long been contested and divided by various rulers, including the Persians and the British. The largest portion of the region lies in southwestern Pakistan. Although it is Pakistan's largest province, comprising 44% of the country's total landmass, its arid, largely desert landscape makes it the country's least populated and least economically developed region.

Before Pakistan was created in 1947, the Balochistan region was divided into two administrative units. One was British Balochistan, which was governed directly by the British. The other comprised several princely states, the largest and most influential of which was the Khanate of Kalat, ruled by Khan Mir Ahmad Yar Khan. Following the end of British rule, the Khanate of Kalat declared itself an independent state on August 15, 1947. Over the following months, Kalat and the newly formed Dominion of Pakistan negotiated the state's future. The talks concluded in March 1948, when Khan Mir Ahmad Yar Khan signed the Instrument of Accession, formally integrating Kalat into Pakistan.

Shortly after the merger in 1948, Prince Abdul Karim, the younger brother of the Khan of Kalat, opposed the decision and launched an armed rebellion from areas near the Afghan border. Historians widely regard this as the first Baloch insurgency. Since then, Balochistan has witnessed several waves of insurgency, with various separatist groups demanding greater autonomy or complete independence. Violent separatist uprisings, largely led by tribal groups, occurred again in 1958, 1962, and 1973.

In the early 2000s, the violence entered a new phase. Baloch nationalists, who had long accused the Pakistani state and military of exploiting Balochistan's valuable mineral resources, oppressing its people, and rigging elections, began to organise themselves into insurgent groups calling for an independent Baloch state. Baloch militants, often operating in large numbers, began carrying out sophisticated attacks on high-profile Pakistani military targets and multimillion-dollar Chinese projects. They also started using suicide bombers. Hundreds of young men and women joined militant organisations such as the Baloch Liberation Army (BLA). Many of those who became radicalised were educated graduates from middle-class families with no prior militant connections. The BLA also became increasingly media-savvy, issuing coordinated press releases following attacks and posting videos across X, TikTok, Telegram, and Instagram glorifying its operations.

In 2017, the BLA, the most prominent Baloch separatist group, underwent a significant transformation. Under the leadership of Aslam Baloch, the organisation shifted away from its dependence on powerful tribal leaders and evolved into a more educated, middle-class movement. He revitalised the Majeed Brigade, the elite suicide bomber unit, and established intelligence and operational wings within the organisation. At the same time, there was a growing loss of faith in political solutions to Balochistan's problems following credible allegations of military interference in the 2018 and 2024 elections, which weakened popular Baloch nationalist politicians. As The Guardian observed, "Violence has become the dominant form of interaction between the state and the Baloch, sidelining and undermining political avenues for addressing the issues."

The Baloch Liberation Army (BLA), a secular ethnonationalist separatist organisation, seeks to establish an independent Balochistan. Since its formation in 2000, the group has steadily expanded both the scale and frequency of its attacks against the Pakistani state, extending its operations across Balochistan Province and neighbouring regions. Some of the BLA's major recent attacks include:

November 27, 2018 – Karachi: The BLA attacked the Chinese Consulate in Karachi, resulting in the deaths of the attackers.

May 15, 2022 – Karachi: The BLA used a female suicide bomber to target Chinese teachers at Karachi University's Confucius Institute, demonstrating its ability to strike targets beyond Balochistan and potentially discourage Chinese investment in Pakistan.

March 11, 2025 – Quetta-Peshawar route: BLA fighters hijacked the Jaffar Express passenger train, killing at least 26 passengers and abducting more than 400 others.

May 31, 2025 – Surab City: The BLA briefly seized control of Surab City, setting up checkpoints on the Quetta-Karachi and Surab-Gidar highways and disrupting movement for several hours.

May 24, 2026 – Quetta: At least 23 people were killed and 71 injured in a suicide bomb attack near a railway station as a train was passing through the area.

July 23, 2026 – Quetta: Suspected militants ambushed and killed a judge and a security guard in Pakistan's restive southwestern region.

Fighters from the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), which is allied with Afghanistan's Taliban, and the banned Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) have continued to target state forces, foreign investment projects, and infrastructure in the mineral-rich region. During the first week of July, rebel fighters reportedly killed 18 police officers and 11 soldiers in separate attacks. Meanwhile, Pakistan's government stated on July 11, 2026, that at least 88 militants had been killed in Balochistan since the launch of a major counterterrorism operation on July 5.

GEOSTRATEGIC IMPORTANCE OF BALOCHISTAN

Balochistan has attracted increasing international attention over the past decade because of its geostrategic importance and vast natural resource base. The province is home to Gwadar Port, located roughly 600 km from the Strait of Hormuz. It provides direct access to the Arabian Sea and serves as a critical gateway connecting Central Asia, the Middle East, and the Indian Ocean's maritime trade routes. In addition, Balochistan possesses some of the world's largest untapped reserves of gold, copper, and rare earth minerals. These strategic and economic assets have drawn the attention of several major powers, particularly the United States and China.

The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), a 3,000-km network of infrastructure projects linking Kashgar in China's Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region with Gwadar Port, is widely regarded as a strategic overland route that allows China to reduce its dependence on the Strait of Malacca for petroleum imports. It is often argued that CPEC makes it highly unlikely that China would support an independent Balochistan or abandon Pakistan. However, a close examination of the CPEC route map suggests that, from China's perspective, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP), the former Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA), and Balochistan are of greater strategic importance than Pakistan's Punjab and Sindh provinces.

Pakistan comprises four provinces—Punjab, Sindh, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, and Balochistan. Islamabad is a federal capital territory, while Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) and Gilgit-Baltistan remain disputed territories. The CPEC route consists of two major corridors: the original western route, which is shorter, and the newer eastern route. The western corridor reaches Balochistan and Gwadar through Gilgit-Baltistan and Dera Ismail Khan, whereas the eastern route passes through Islamabad and Lahore before continuing through Punjab and Sindh to Gwadar.

For decades, nationalist and militant groups in Balochistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa have sought greater autonomy or separation from Pakistan. Some analysts argue that the possibility of Pakistan fragmenting into smaller political entities, driven by economic instability, entrenched feudal structures, and ethno-nationalist grievances, cannot be entirely ruled out. They further contend that major powers such as China and the United States could find it easier to engage with smaller, politically stable states than with a fragmented but larger Pakistan. Consequently, some observers argue that the emergence of an independent Balochistan in the future cannot be completely discounted.

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1 BADGE, THREE TECHS

3 FAMILIES OF HYBRIDS

4 TYPES OF POWERTRAIN

Hybrid? or Hybrid-ish?

As Indians begin to drive electric, 'Hybrid' has become one of the auto industry's most potent marketing tools. The trouble is that not every hybrid is created equal

AUTHOR

RAJEEV NARAYAN

Walk into three different car showrooms and ask for a 'Hybrid'. Chances are you will be shown three very different cars, each wearing the same badge. One will assist its petrol engine while accelerating. Another will glide through city traffic on electric power alone. A third will blur the lines between a conventional petrol car and an electric vehicle. They may all be called hybrids, but they are anything but identical.

That is the irony of India's evolving auto market. In the rush to go electric, 'Hybrid' has become as much a marketing proposition as an engineering description. The word has a magical appeal, reassuring buyers that they are buying cleaner, more efficient technology without the compromises of an EV. The problem is that the badge tells only half the story, creating hopes that not every hybrid is designed to fulfil.

Don't blame the manufacturers. Consumers prefer simple descriptions, but marketing teams love familiar terminology, and even automotive journalists use the word loosely to avoid lengthy technical explanations. But slowly, the distinction between various types of hybrids has blurred. The result is that buyers often assume they are comparing similar technology when, in reality, they are not. Not at all.

GLOBAL GALLOP

The confusion in India is striking because the global story has moved far beyond clever marketing. Across Japan, Europe, North America and China, hybrids have matured into an engineering success story. What began three decades ago with Toyota's pioneering Prius has evolved into a family of technologies that combine internal combustion engines with electric motors in remarkably sophisticated ways.

Toyota alone has sold lakhs of hybrid vehicles, proving that electrification does not mean battery-electric vehicles alone. Honda has refined its acclaimed e-architecture, while Hyundai and Kia offer hybrid variants across multiple global models. Renault, Nissan and other European automakers have expanded their hybrid portfolios too, recognising that today's customers value flexibility over ideology.

The focus on hybrids comes just as the explosive growth of battery EVs has begun to moderate globally. Governments may promote zero-emission mobility, but consumers are seeking solutions that eliminate range anxiety without sacrificing efficiency. Auto firms have responded – instead of betting on any one tech, they are investing in EVs, strong hybrids, plug-in hybrids and even extended-range electric vehicles, proof that the journey towards decarbonisation will be more evolutionary than revolutionary.

India too appears destined to follow this multi-technology path.

INDIA'S REALITY

India needs cleaner mobility, but it also faces realities that many developed markets do not. Public charging infrastructure remains concentrated in larger cities. Apartment-dwellers lack dedicated charging units. Inter-city charging networks are expanding but are yet to inspire true confidence. Battery EVs are becoming affordable but remain beyond the reach of most middle-income buyers.

For lakhs of motorists, a hybrid offers a middle path. It promises better fuel efficiency, lower emissions, familiar refuelling, no charging anxiety and an overall experience that needs no behavioural adjustment. For buyers who undertake long-distance travel or cannot easily install home chargers, the proposition becomes compelling.

Yet, an irony remains. India does offer capable 'Strong Hybrids', but they are the exception. Most vehicles marketed as 'Hybrid' rely on mild-hybrid systems that improve efficiency and refinement, but cannot propel the vehicle independently. Mild hybrids are fine – affordable, less complex and good for economy. The problem is that buyers assume every hybrid delivers the same experience. That is total gibberish.

BEYOND BUZZWORDS

This is where engineering separates itself from advertising. The most basic end of the spectrum is the 'Mild Hybrid'. Employing a compact 12V or 48V electrical system, it assists the petrol or diesel engine during acceleration, enables smoother stop-start operation and recovers energy during braking. The electric motor, however, cannot independently drive the vehicle. It is an assistant, not a partner.

> HYBRIDS MAY BE THE BRIDGE TO CLEAN MOBILITY, BUT BUYERS DESERVE TO KNOW IF THEY ARE *purchasing* A MILD HELPER, TRUE HYBRID OR SOMETHING IN BETWEEN

A 'Strong Hybrid' or 'Full Hybrid' is a different animal altogether. Here, the engine and electric motor work in harmony, deciding which should propel the vehicle. In start-stop city traffic, motors on the wheels power the car. When hard acceleration happens, the engine and the motors both work to deliver stronger output. And when the brakes are applied, and batteries are regenerated without any external charging.

As for 'Plug-in hybrids', they have larger batteries that propel the car for long distances on electricity before the petrol engine wakes up. They offer the pluses of an EV while retaining the convenience of a fuel tank. Their limited presence in India is more due to pricing and taxation than any technological shortcomings.

A fourth category attracting attention is the 'Extended-Range Electric Vehicle'. Here, the wheels are driven by electric motors while the ICE powertrain functions only as a generator to recharge the battery. It is neither a conventional hybrid nor a pure electric vehicle, yet a reminder that electrification is no longer a simple, one-size-fits-all proposition.

CHANGING GEARS

The good news is that India's hybrid landscape is maturing. Toyota has led with its Strong Hybrid tech underpinning the Urban Cruiser Hyryder and Innova HyCross. Through its partnership with Toyota, Maruti Suzuki has brought the same architecture to the Grand Vitara and Invicto. Honda's City-E has shown that sophisticated hybrid tech need not be confined to premium SUVs.

Successful hybrids such as Toyota's RAV4, Honda's ZR-V and Hyundai's Tucson will bolster their electrified portfolios in India, subject to product and market strategies. Further, Renault and Nissan have plans to expand hybrid vehicles globally, making India a logical destination as consumer demand evolves. The direction of travel is unmistakable.

BRIDGING TOMORROW

The future of mobility in India is unlikely to belong to any one tech. EVs will become common as battery prices decline and charging networks expand. ICE will evolve through clean fuels, better fuel efficiency and low emissions. Between these two worlds lie hybrids, combining familiarity with meaningful electrification.

It is time we move beyond the blanket word 'Hybrid'. A truer description such as Mild Hybrid, Strong Hybrid or Plug-in Hybrid will inform buyers more about the vehicle than a generic badge ever will. Consumers deserve transparency, not terminology. Because buying a car should not require decoding engineering jargon or marketing nuance, and the bridge between petrol and electric is finally taking shape.

BEYOND RISING SEA LEVELS

A new global study suggests that land subsidence, driven largely by human activity, is accelerating flood risks in river deltas and coastal cities, pushing climate threats decades closer than previously projected

AUTHOR

KRISHNA GUPTA

A recent news report on a study on the threat of rising sea levels to deltas and various cities caught my attention because it named Kolkata (where I currently reside) as a city where the subsidence rates are higher than the surrounding delta-wide average. The study was conducted by the University of East Anglia, Shanghai Normal University, the University of California, Irvine, the University of Southampton, and other institutions from around the world. The results were first published on 3rd December in the magazine One Earth and on 14th January, 2026, in the journal Nature. Coincidentally, 14th January was also the occasion of Makar Sankranti, celebrated with great fervour in the Gangasagar delta (where the Ganges meets the Bay of Bengal) near Kolkata, oblivious of the imminent danger to the surrounding areas.

SUBSIDENCE: A SERIOUS THREAT TO COASTAL CITIES

The aforementioned study was co-authored by Asst Prof Leonard Ohenhen of the University of California, Irvine, and Prof Robert Nicholls of the University of East Anglia (Tyndall Centre for Climate Change Research). It was focused on Shanghai but also covered 40 other river deltas, such as the Mekong, Nile, Ganges-Brahmaputra, Mahanadi, Godavari, Mississippi, Yellow River, etc.

The study's main finding across deltas is that subsidence is exacerbating the threat from rising sea levels. In fact, in 18 of the 40 deltas studied, the current average subsidence rate is greater than the rate of sea-level rise and will impact 236 million people. While the rate of subsidence varies across deltas, almost every delta has areas where the subsidence is higher than the sea-level rise. What is of even greater concern is that ground subsidence dominates the rise in sea levels in many of these deltas, even in worst-case scenarios, which implies that people in these deltas have to worry about sinking ground along with a rising sea. The reasons for this subsidence are man-made and include excessive extraction of groundwater, reduced sedimentation, and rapid urbanisation. Closer home, the Ganges-Brahmaputra, Mahanadi, and Godavari deltas are all sinking, with subsidence exceeding sea-level rise in the Ganges-Brahmaputra and Godavari deltas. The Ganges-Brahmaputra delta is the most affected, with large areas sinking faster than the sea level is rising and a large population residing in these sinking areas. It is pertinent to note here that this study confirms the findings of Philip Minderhoud of Utrecht University, who found that the Mekong delta was subsiding faster than the sea level was rising. In his 'Rise and Fall' project, he found that this subsidence was the result of massive groundwater extraction, which was leading to food security issues.

These findings are important because they will force us to revise the timelines for when coastal areas will submerge below the sea. As we know, relative sea-level rise is a combination of sea-level rise and land subsidence. With land subsidence emerging as far more serious than earlier thought, the timelines are bound to change, advancing by decades the point at which submergence could occur in coastal and delta areas. To take one example, the subsidence observed in the Ganges-Brahmaputra delta is 5-10 mm per year, which translates to a relative sea-level rise of 9-14 mm per year. This will advance chronic flooding and even submergence in some areas to as early as 2035-2055, as opposed to 2070-80, as predicted by earlier climate models. This would have an impact on cities in the Ganges-Brahmaputra delta, such as Kolkata, Puri, and Rajahmundry. A similar situation would be faced by river deltas across the world: the Mekong in Vietnam, the Chao Phraya in Thailand, the Yellow River and Pearl River in China, the Nile and Tigris-Euphrates in Africa, the Po in Italy, and the Mississippi in the USA. In all these cases, climate-only sea-level rise projections will be dominated by subsidence. In other words, subsidence will accelerate the adverse impacts by years.

Governments would need modified drainage, flood protection, water and sanitation infrastructure, and protection for transport infrastructure such as railways and metro systems. All existing infrastructure, such as bridges, roads, and levees, would need to be re-inspected, strengthened, and, where necessary, rebuilt. Furthermore, new coastal zoning rules would be necessary, and large funds would need to be allocated for building flood-protection infrastructure. In urban areas, a new Building Code would have to be notified to ensure protection against flooding and even shift new construction to higher ground. Even existing city residences would have to be retrofitted over the next 10-15 years through measures such as vacating lower floors, changing the outer envelopes of buildings, strengthening foundations, etc.

> **THE GREATEST** coastal threat may no longer be only the rising sea, but the sinking land beneath our feet

CONCLUSION

Climate-induced sea-level rise, resulting from the melting of glaciers and polar ice caps, is well known and already integrated into climate models and policymaking. However, widespread and rapid subsidence due to excessive groundwater extraction, reduced sediment loads in rivers, and rapid urbanisation in river deltas has presented a new challenge. This additional factor will bring forward flooding in coastal areas as well as submergence in deltas by decades when compared with climate-only sea-level rise projections. Governments need to be ready for this challenge with better infrastructure, new coastal zoning rules, and updated building codes.

The Grand Dame of History's Devotion to Poetry

Romila Thapar's memoir Just Being reveals that one of India's greatest historians has long drawn intellectual strength from poetry, finding in verse not only solace but also a deeper way of understanding history, memory and truth

AUTHOR

SUBHORANJAN DASGUPTA

Epigraph

"How did Subho guess that I carry a secret poet within me, to whom I have never been able to give a voice. It remains an unfulfilled anguished 'khwaish' (Romila Thapar)".

"Your *Just Being / A Memoir* serves as the most remarkable testimony of your passionate attachment to poets and poetry and how the latter have also left their mark in your historiography." (Subhoranjan)

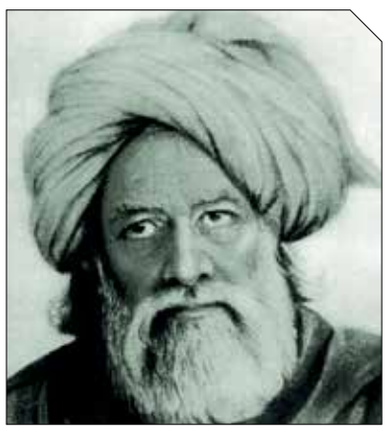
The most renowned philosopher of our times, Hans-Georg Gadamer, prefaced his seminal text Truth and Method not with a historic statement from his illustrious predecessors like Wilhelm Leibniz or Immanuel Kant. He chose instead some evocative lines from the most sensitive German poet of the last century, Rainer Maria Rilke. Gadamer had taught at Heidelberg University where I had also been engaged in research. So, I had the opportunity to ask him, "Why a poem as epigraph?" His reply was memorable, "Rilke's poems help me to understand the phenomenology of Edmund Husserl!'

Our most renowned historian, Romila Thapar's Memoir/Just Being, which was published some days ago by Seagull, has also not begun with a historic statement from Thucydides, Theodor Mommsen or someone closer to us like D.D. Kosambi. On one separate page, right at the beginning, she has zeroed in on a revelatory poem by Faiz Ahmed Faiz, whom Edward Said has described as the most eloquent Urdu poet of the last century. Romila Thapar's fervent reverence for Faiz does not require any footnote. She has quoted those very lines which articulate the first and foremost vow of every historian, worth his or her salt :

Speak, for even this brief moment is ample
Prior to the dying of body and tongue.
Speak, that truth still lives,
Speak, to say whatever is to be said.

It is this fearless and determined dedication to truth uttered by the Marxist poet and practised by the progressive historian that explains why the latter brushed away deaththreats and fought with exemplary fervour mythmaking,

Faiz Ahmed Faiz



Bulleh Shah

construction of legends and plain propagation of untruth in the name of history.

We are not surprised when we read that this historian, and no other from India, was invited to deliver the Faiz Ahmed Faiz Memorial Lecture in 1992 in Lahore. The audience stood up and gave her an ovation that was simply not ceasing. Indeed, they were paying homage to the historian and the poet in one effusive breath. Recalling this rapturous event, Romila wrote "Remembering Faiz became an occasion and I was very happy to have been part of it, fond as I am of Faiz's poems …because they touch my being in so many ways." (Page 396)

Faiz and Romila shared, more or less, the same cosmovision. But the Anglican,

T.S. Eliot

Dylan Thomas

Roman Catholic T.S. Eliot was conservative to the core. This basic disparity however did not bother her because she was intrinsically Catholic like Karl Marx who was prepared to admire even the royalist Balzac. What fascinated her was that Eliot had unraveled the crucial link – often complex – between the past, present and future. This temporal connection constitutes the very pulsebeat of history. Hence, she has quoted from the first long poem Burnt Norton in Four Quartets those revelatory lines :

Time present and time past
Are both perhaps present in time future
And time future contained in time past.
If all time is eternally present
All time is unredeemable.

Mayakovsky

To cement the bond between her and her another favourite poet, Eliot, Romila prefaced this quote with the following words : "The voice you hear in these pages is that of my limited reflections. Yet it is my voice. Through time, it evokes the past, touches on the present and hints at the future." (Prologue, XIX)

The bug bit her as well. Inspired by Faiz, Eliot, Dylan Thomas, Anna Akhmatova, Vladimir Mayakovsky and others, she could not resist the temptation of composing verse herself. But then she had the perspicacity to keep these under wraps. They were designed to respond to an intense, personal urge and nothing more. Her disclosure reveals how close she has remained devoted to the Muse, "I decided that I would write poems only for myself … These range from doggerels to freeverse. The freeverse at least tried to capture my conversations with myself." (Page 58)

I earnestly feel that not merely spiritual enlightenment but also the medium in which it was expressed, namely poetry, drew this historian inexorably to Bhakti Literature. Bhakti poetry celebrated the communion of humanity and unsullied love, hence she greeted Sant Kabir and Bulleh Shah with undiminished ardour. She heard absorbed the musical renderings of the Punjabi folk poet Bulleh Shah by Nusrat Fate Ali Khan and Abida Parvin. She aspired for more, "I wish I had read more on the Punjab linked to the time of Bulleh Shah" (Page 266). I hazard a guess here – perhaps this poet was to Punjab what Lalon was to Bengali, both trampling the divisiveness of organized faiths with impunity.

Like her close friend Amartya Sen (with whom I spoke on the same subject), Romila also realized the limits of social science. While the latter is logical, meaningful and guided by reason, poetry or creativity opens another world where the word and feeling acquire another glory and splendor, at times ineffable. She has explained the distinction admirably, "Poetry can grow in that aura whereas academic writing perforce has to confine itself to the commonly understood meaning. Poems can be provocative in raising new images and this may take one's thoughts to other than the mundane." (Page 647).

She discussed the intricacies of poetry with the Mexican poet Octavio Paz; she was roused by the restless verse of Dylan Thomas; she repeated the defiant words of Mayakovsky "Beat on the street … the march of rebellion"; she tried to translate the Hindi poems of Mahadevi Varma into English as an act of self-exploration; she listened intently to Ted Hughes reciting the poems of T.S. Eliot. In a word, she felt and lived poetry with her entire being.

I have only one poignant query with which I shall end. The historian loved her father ardently because he had supported her quest for autonomy and liberty unceasingly, and her favourite poet, the mercurial Dylan Thomas, was also devoted to his father. When the latter saw his father approaching the irrevocable end, he wrote those absolutely mesmerising lines, perhaps his very best,

Do not go gentle into that goodnight
Old age should burn and rave at close of day.
Rage, rage against the dying of the light.

Who knows – the impact of poesy is so inscrutable – probably the historian also whispered this impassioned appeal when she saw her father eclipsing, though she has not explicitly stated it in her masterpiece. Possibly, the historian in love with poetry, did in heartfelt silence.

Waiting for Yama, Living Still

Jerry Pinto's graceful translation revives Rajendra Banahatti's timeless meditation on ageing, memory, dignity and the quiet defiance of living beyond expectation

AUTHOR

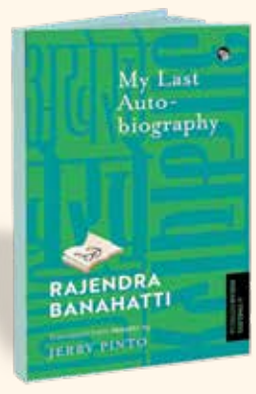
SANJEEV CHOPRA

43 years after it was penned by Rajendra Banahatti in 1982, *Akherche Atmacharitra* has been given a new lease of life by Jerry Pinto's excellent translation under the title 'My Last Autobiography'. Banahatti's protagonist as himself is a 94-year-old 'immortal engineer' who speaks of his shrinking world with a sense of profound understanding. He bears no malice, but is not unaware of how his favourite son, a well-established doctor, goes through the motions of being concerned about his health and welfare even as he actually becomes increasingly irritated with his father's unexpected longevity.

Apart from deeper philosophical questions about the purpose of life and the meaning of death, this book gives us an idea of how everyday norms changed from the 1890s to 1980s. These included the salience of fasts and feasts to mark special occasions, and the recall of events as per the Indic calendar - *Paush, Magh and Phalgun* - instead of January, February and March. The All India Radio was the most important and perhaps the only source of news, entertainment and information about everything from national and global affairs to cinema to cricket to crop advisories for farmers. We also learn that Rs 450/per month was the pension for a high-ranking government engineer: a sum good enough for a comfortable existence if one lived in one's own house.

A word about the world of Ajoba — the father of four sons and four daughters, of whom one was estranged for she had eloped with a Parsi boy. At this advanced stage of life, his most salient interactions are with his maids Sitabai who looks after him from dawn to dusk, and Chandrabai who takes over from her for the night shift. His son calls on him at least twice a day, with a stethoscope in hand, while going to and coming back from his clinic on the ground floor of the three-storeyed house which they inhabit together.

His wife, whom he had married when she was ten and he was sixteen, had passed on a decade earlier. Theirs had been a fine partnership for seventy-five years. He misses her affection and companionship, as well as her



culinary skills – homemade modaks, shrikhand and the range of vegetable dishes from bottle gourd, turnips, yam, beans, capsicum and a wide variety of pickles. The memory of those delicious foods endure, and he cannot stand the staid staple fare offered instead by his daughter-in-law Suman, a working professional who held the view that cooking was the 'territory of servants'. Suman exercised complete control over the household expenses, and along with her husband had fixed his discretionary spending at Rs 50 per month.

Where and how does a nonagenarian who cannot move out of his room spend his money? The first expense

> 'My Last Autobiography' is an intimate exploration of growing old, retaining agency and finding meaning in the ordinary rituals of everyday life

is on the barber who shaves his beard once a week and his head once a fortnight. The second is for vegetables which he buys when Suman is not at home (which is more often than not). But this gives him the 'power' to decide what he wants to eat. His third indulgence is on perfume and attar, for now he cannot go to the garden to capture the fragrance of the flowers. Last but not the least is the expenditure for his palate again - he is fond of pedha, barfi, kalakand, farsan, Threptin biscuits, and buys extra sugar to add to the tepid tea which is made as per Suman's instructions.

When he suffers a paralytic attack, his son's friend, Dr Sukhatme whispers that 'the old man had just seven or eight days to live'. These were the best days of his life, for the extended circle of friends and family all came rushing to call on him to express his concern about failing health. His tenant from the first floor comes with a copy of the Bhagwad Geeta and reads from the second chapter (Samkhya Yoga): *Vaansansi jeernaananiya thaavi haay...* Just as a person sheds old clothes… the implication is that it is time for him to say his final goodbyes.

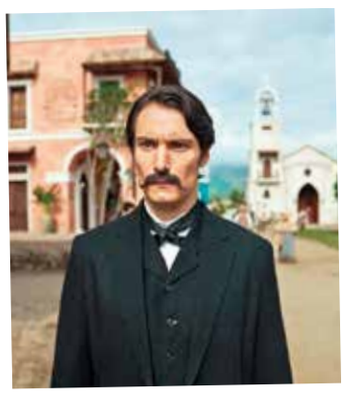
His eldest son, Nana, a pensioner like him, wants to start work on his autobiography! That indeed would be a very different kind of narrative, for unlike our protagonist who looked forward to a transfer every few years – from Karachi to Quetta, from Lahore to Mangalore to Cochin and Trivandrum – which gave him the chance to explore new cities and make new friends, Nana would feign sickness and make all kinds of excuses to avoid any change in the set pattern of his life.

Even as these 'last visits' continue, much to the shock of everyone around him, he not only survives the designated period assigned to him but also manages to regain control of his limbs. Now he hallucinates between life and death, and the interregnum in between, so much so that all around him start regarding him as a living demon. Is he senile, or frustrated, or are others around him unwilling to accept what he is at his age when the hands tremble, the heart is weak and the digestion is indifferent, but the mind is still alert… for it retains its reservoirs of memory, as well as the strong desire to assert authority over his son and certainly over his other caregivers!

Why is this book called *The Last Autobiography?* He wrote his first autobiography when he was sixty-five, and the second when he became *Sahastra Chandra Darshan* - a person who has seen one thousand full moons in a milestone that usually occurs around the age of 80 years and 8 months. He is looking forward to welcoming the Lord of Death, Yama, who refuses to embrace him, and thus leaves him and others around him distraught. But the closing lines of this book offer the possibility of yet another edition, for he says 'As we live, we write. And as we write, we live. In other words, who knows if this is the last autobiography, the last word? Who can say?'

Thank you, Jerry, for this wonderful story of a man who is dismissed by the world as having outlived his innings. To me, this is a story of hope, of meditation and memory; it reminded me of Nirad Chaudhary's 'Horsemen of the Third Apocalypse' also written in his centenary year. Thank you to Rajendra, for writing this remarkable autobiography about the inevitability of our human bodies aging—and living, despite it all.

WHEN 'RIVER OF FIRE' MEETS 'ONE HUNDRED YEARS OF SOLITUDE'



Like Márquez, Hyder set out to do nothing less than write the biography of a civilisation, reclaiming its memory from the clinical, divisive hierarchy left behind by empire

ASIF ULLAH KHAN

We went too far in our thinking and forgot that destinies are written…"
— *Mahmoud Darwish,*
the celebrated Palestinian poet

When Gabriel García Márquez published 'One Hundred Years of Solitude' in 1967, it fundamentally changed the landscape of Latin American literature. Almost overnight, it shattered the rigid, imported structures of European realism, offering instead a mythic, cyclical canvas that captured the true, turbulent soul of a continent. It was hailed as a singular, unprecedented revolution in global letters.

Yet, eight years before Macondo was swept away by the wind, a similarly quiet revolution had already taken place in the Urdu language. In 1959, Qurratulain Hyder published 'Aag Ka Dariya' (River of Fire). The title 'Aag Ka Dariya' is taken from one of the most famous couplets of Urdu poet Jigar Moradabadi:

'Yeh ishq nahi aasaan bas itna samajh lijiye/ Ek aag ka darya hai aur doob ke jaana hai'.

('This thing called love is not easy, understand just this much/ It is a river of fire, and one must drown to cross it').

The most famous and defining quote about the book came from 'The Times Literary Supplement', which wrote: "To Urdu fiction what 'One Hundred Years of Solitude' is to Hispanic literature."

Like Márquez, Hyder set out to do nothing less than write the biography of a civilisation, reclaiming its memory from the clinical, divisive hierarchy left behind by empire. Together, these two masterpieces stand as the twin peaks of 20th-century post-colonial literature, each using a radical reimagining of time to heal the wounds of history.

The two novels were born nearly 15,000 kilometres apart - in Colombia and the Indian subcontinent - but they appear to flow from the same philosophical river. Both ask the same unsettling question: Can civilisations escape the cycle of creation and destruction?

The most obvious similarity lies in their treatment of generations.

For Márquez, changing Latin American literature meant turning the novel into a mirror of absolute solitude. In the swamp-ringed isolation of Macondo, the Buendía family is trapped in a hereditary prison. Time does not march forward; it spins on a fixed, decaying axis. Generations inherit not just the same names - the Aurelianos and José Arcadios - but the same inability to love and the same drift toward self-destruction.

This cyclical trap was Márquez's way of representing the historical paralysis of Latin America, a region repeatedly pillaged by civil war, foreign banana companies and domestic dictatorships. The ultimate fate of Macondo is pre-written in Melquíades' Sanskrit parchments - a fatalistic blueprint that dooms the town to be wiped from the earth the moment it is finally deciphered. In this universe, history is a closed room and solitude is the heavy, inescapable price of existence.

Qurratulain Hyder's 'Aag Ka Dariya', however, approaches civilisational destiny through a completely different metaphysical geometry. Where Márquez constructs a spiral, Hyder charts a river. Her narrative is a sweeping, relentless flow that spans over two and a half millennia of the Indian subcontinent, moving from the classical Maurya period, through the medieval Lodhi and Mughal dynasties, into the colonial British Raj and finally crashing into the catastrophic trauma of the 1947 Partition.

To navigate this immense ocean of time, Hyder employs a brilliant, modernistic device: her four core characters - Gautam Nilambar, Kamaluddin, Champa, Cyril Ashley and other characters repeatedly reappear across different historical eras. Sometimes they bear different names, sometimes different religions, sometimes different social positions, yet they remain recognisably the same souls journeying through history. They are not literal reincarnations in a strict theological sense, but rather recurring cultural archetypes. Unlike the Buendías, who are doomed by their lack of historical memory, Hyder's characters carry the unconscious, inherited weight of their ancestors' unresolved debates. They don't remember their past lives, but they live out the continuous, evolving argument of what it means to belong to the land.

THE TWO NOVELS WERE BORN NEARLY 15,000 KILOMETRES APART – IN COLOMBIA AND THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT – BUT THEY APPEAR TO FLOW FROM THE SAME PHILOSOPHICAL RIVER

This divergence in their structures reflects a deeper divergence in their tragedies. 'Aag Ka Dariya' is, at its heart, an elegiac tribute to the subcontinent's composite culture - its Ganga-Jamuni *tehzeeb.* Hyder painstakingly documents how centuries of Buddhist, Hindu, Muslim and Sufi interactions didn't merely collide, but fused to create a unique, pluralistic civilisational fabric.

The tragedy of her novel is not the internal, spiritual isolation of Macondo, but a violent, external fragmentation. The Partition of 1947 acts as a literal bisection of this composite soul. When Kamal, a Muslim intellectual, chooses to migrate to Pakistan, his grief is not merely personal; it's the existential agony of a unified identity being forcibly halved by a political border.

In contrast, the tragedy of Macondo is its absolute, baseline isolation. Cut off from the world, the Buendías suffer from an inability to forge community or express genuine intimacy. When the outside world finally breaches Macondo's borders, it doesn't integrate; it exploits and discards. While Hyder mourns the shattering of a shared home that once existed, Márquez mourns the tragic, systemic inability to build a shared home in the first place.

To capture these expansive visions, both writers had to shatter the conventions of the traditional realist novel. Márquez famously turned to magical realism, blending the fantastical with the mundane so seamlessly that a girl floating to heaven while folding bedsheets is treated with the same matter-of-fact precision as a military massacre. This was a political choice - using myth, folklore and the supernatural as a shield against the sanitised, official histories written by Latin American dictatorships.

Hyder, on the other hand, pioneered a lyrical, modernist realism in Urdu literature. She combined classic poetic sensibilities and Persian literary traditions with Western modernist techniques, shifting effortlessly into stream of consciousness and internal monologue. Her prose is intellectual, elegiac and deeply cinematic, capturing the psychological weight of historical transitions.

Ultimately, both novels represent a triumph of post-colonial reclamation. During the Raj, colonial historians often divided Indian history into neat, segregated eras - the Hindu, the Muslim, the British - a division that paved the way for the tragedy of Partition. Hyder's masterpiece rejects this linear, sectarian classification, presenting instead an unbroken, fluid civilisational consciousness that refuses to be neatly filed away. Márquez similarly reclaimed Latin American history from the Eurocentric narrative of 'discovery' and 'savagery', transforming the struggles of his continent into a universal mythology.

The river in 'Aag Ka Dariya' continues to flow, open-ended and scarred, carrying its fractured survivors into an uncertain future. The mirror in 'One Hundred Years of Solitude' is shattered, wiping Macondo off the earth in an act of absolute, tragic finality. But in both cases, the novels themselves survive as acts of defiance - reminding us that when history is written by the victors, literature is often the only vessel left to preserve the truth of who we were and who we hoped to become.

Perhaps the deepest connection between the novels is their portrayal of civilisational decline. Where Márquez destroys a town, Hyder chronicles the fragmentation of an entire civilizational spectrum. The endings are equally devastating. In the end, 'One Hundred Years of Solitude' and 'Aag Ka Dariya' are not merely novels about families or nations. They are meditations on the mortality of civilisations themselves. One imagines history as a circle, the other as a river. But both remind us that no empire, culture or family can survive if it loses its memory.

Was spoilt for choice when it came to lessons: Tom Holland

The actor opened up about working in Christopher Nolan's 'The Odyssey'

BEDIKA

Standing in the middle of the room when the camera's not rolling and just observing co-stars Anne Hathaway and Matt Damon. Those, said actor Tom Holland, could well be some of his most loved moments from shooting Christopher Nolan's 'The Odyssey'. The 30-year-old, who made a splash with his turn as Spider-Man in a series of movies, plays Odysseus's son Telemachus in Nolan's film based on Homer's epic about a war-weary hero's treacherous journey back home.

The retelling of the story from Greek mythology is an action-heavy exercise with monsters, vengeful gods and other fantastical characters. There were moments when Holland was present on set but had nothing to do. Those stand out for him.

"What I love about being an actor is that there are times on set where you really get to stand in the middle of the room and do nothing. And that's when the camera's not rolling," Holland told PTI in an interview.

He added, "And for me, I like to learn from people by watching them and watching the way they behave and treat people and work with people. So, for me, I had the perfect footprints to try and follow in Annie and in Matt. So, I was kind of spoilt for choice when it comes to lessons."

Nolan, Damon and Holland were recently in Mumbai this weekend for the India premiere as part of a global tour.

Working with Nolan was like a dream come true for the young actor, who had long been told that he must do whatever it takes to get himself on a film by the director. "I definitely had a very long conversation with Robert Downey Jr," Holland said, referring to his 'Marvel' co-star who won an Oscar for 'Best Supporting Actor' for Nolan's last release 'Oppenheimer'.

"And then one of my best friends in life has worked with Chris for, I think, 20 years. He's our stunt coordinator. And every time he and I got together for dinner, he would tell me, 'You have to do whatever it takes to find yourself on a Christopher Nolan set'," he added.

It finally happened.

There were moments when Holland was present on set but had nothing to do. Those stand out for him

'The Odyssey', arguably Nolan's most ambitious film, is one that Holland describes as the first of its kind. "For a community of people that love cinema as much as you guys do here, this will be one of those moments you'll be comparing every cinema experience you have after this one to 'The Odyssey'," he told PTI.

Holland didn't have as many action sequences as Damon, who plays Odysseus. But there were challenges aplenty. "I think the biggest challenge and I feel a little embarrassed saying this because I didn't work as hard as Matt did, but it was the endurance. This story is epic and the adventure that we're going on is as grand as any. And finding that energy and keeping up that momentum for the duration of the shoot was really, really difficult. I can only imagine what that must have been like for Matt and his crew. It was just the daily struggle of trying to make sure that what we were doing felt epic for me was probably the biggest challenge," Holland said.

This was the 'Uncharted' star's second visit to Mumbai. He had come earlier in 2023 for an event. "I am always touched by how welcoming everyone is. I want to see the countryside. I want to kind of explore more outside the bigger cities and meet people," he said.

Holland also recounted a dinner experience during his three-day visit this time. "It wasn't just a dinner. It was an experience. Every dish came with a piece of knowledge and information about Indian culture, you know, even as far as the cutlery we used to the types of cups we were using. And for me coming here, I come from England and we have a huge Indian population in England," he said.

AGENCIES